

Chapter One – Drip Feed

Trials always seemed to start the same: sharp inhale, tug behind the ribs, then boots on asphalt and the hum of the Fog fading off.

Dwight blinked against the gray light of the Bedham Preschool domain. The air already felt heavier here, like the whole world had exhaled but never breathed back in. The Fog deposited them separately, the way it sometimes did — Dwight materializing at the far end of the street, David a half-block down and already scanning the sightlines before he'd fully arrived. They found each other without incident.

A quick glance around told them they were alone at the moment; the others having been dropped in somewhere else. That was fine. Normal. Survivors rarely arrived as a full set, and Badham's twisted little playground was familiar enough not to panic about.

The preschool sat low against the grey sky, its painted murals faded to suggestions of color, the chain-link fence around the yard sagging in places where rust had won the argument with the metal. Neither of them had pulled Bedham in a while, the Entity seeming to favor the woodsier domains as of late for some reason. Dwight tried to remember if there was anything particular about the layout worth flagging and came up mostly empty. Standard build. Tight interior.

The basement generator was the move — killers avoided it because the pipe hallway that divided the lower level into two rooms was a nightmare to navigate, all jutting valves and blind corners, and there were two ways up instead of one. It was the kind of start that let you bank some early progress before things went sideways, turning chases into slow collisions and smug laughter. You could get a gen nearly done before they even thought about trying. It was the easiest way to relax before the real chases started. Get your bearings, work out the rust from joints. So long as the killer wasn't one of the teleporting ones, it should be easy enough.

David seemed to be running the same thought, as he sized up the immediate area, took one look at the weathered shell of the preschool and sighed, squaring his shoulders. "Boiler room?"

"Boiler room," Dwight echoed.

They crossed the threshold into the school, ducking under a rusted EXIT sign that had long since given up. Bedham never had doors — none of the buildings seemed to — just openings where the idea of a door had been removed, neat rectangles cut through plaster and expectation. Dwight had stopped finding it strange years ago — the absence of doors was just part of the grammar of this place, the particular way the Entity assembled things from memory and

suggestion rather than reality. The hall beyond breathed dust. Paper curls clung to a corkboard with sun-bleached pushpins. A child's drawing of a house had flaked down to a white outline of someplace else. Light pooled in thin yellow lines through warped blinds, and dust swirled lazily in the shafts like it was still caught mid-class.

A noise from deeper in — something heavy scraping tile; a crash of furniture meeting wall — made both of them drop without thinking, pressing back against the hallway lockers. A second sound followed, wood on metal, unnecessary and dramatic. David angled Dwight behind him on reflex, only to freeze when the source revealed itself down the far corridor: Ghostface, draped in black and carelessly visible, filming his own vandalism as if bored by the lack of applause. He shoved a locker door until it bounced back, then flicked his phone toward it like he was rating the performance.

He wasn't stalking. He wasn't even paying attention to the building around him, which was the only reason he hadn't already seen them. He was filming himself on his phone with one hand and picking up a small plastic chair with the other, examining it with the critical eye of someone who had found something deeply disappointing. He turned it over once, seemed to find it lacking, and hurled it sideways into the wall with a hollow clatter that echoed the length of the building.

"Just Ghostface," he muttered with a small eyeroll, shaking his head lightly as the tension left his shoulders. "Looks like he's in one of his moods."

Dwight nodded. The relief came with a small, wry exhale. A visible killer was a polite killer. Danny's menace lived in the corners — no point wasting fear when he was being obvious. As long as he wasn't looking their way, who cared? If the killer was already goofing around like this, he was clearly not in the mood to do a proper hunt. So long as everyone stayed out of his line of sight, they should be fine. Had he actually cared today, he would have been stealthed, and they might have missed him entirely.

Danny moved on down the far corridor without once looking their way, already pointing his phone at something else. The faint sound of his own commentary floated back to them, too distant to make out.

They gave it a moment before moving again.

They took the opposite stairwell, easing down into the basement beneath flickering bulbs and rust-streaked walls. Dwight tried not to notice the way his shoulder brushed the wall with every step. It felt narrower than it should've, but that was just adrenaline. It had to be. It was a preschool, after all. Made for small bodies. It didn't help that Danny's terror radius had a

particular weight to it, a low crawling pressure that played tricks if you let it. Even on the other side of the building, it thrummed uncomfortably against his chest. That's all this was, most likely. Just nerves.

The generator waited at the far wall—half-skinned, half-sunk in a trap of its own piping. Dwight's hands found the familiar metal and the familiar thrill of making something uncooperative do what it was told. It caught on the third try, settled into its familiar grind, and they fell into the rhythm of it without needing to discuss it. Sparks jumped and died. The hum of effort thrummed through the casing into his palms. David set opposite him, matching rhythm without comment. The work made sense. It borrowed your brain and filled it with timing. It felt good to be able to ignore the usual tension of a trial for a bit and just do something repetitive.

For a while, that was enough.

Snap. Click. Turn. Hold.

Routine.

And yet... something itched under Dwight's skin almost immediately.

Dwight frowned against the odd ambience. A strange noise, he could understand. That kind of thing was common, if concerning in of itself. This though? This felt...weird. The basement had a quality to its silence that didn't sit right — not the comfortable quiet of a space with nobody in it, but something closer to held breath. Could always be just the generator dampening other sounds, he mused. Normally he didn't notice that effect, but he also didn't usually have the time to stop and listen to the area around him for long before needing to run or hide.

Shaking off the eeriness, Dwight shifted his position slightly and tried to focus back on what he was doing. If he let his mind wander too much, he could miss a spark, and the killer would DEFINITELY hear a generator misfire. Even Danny couldn't ignore that kind of a blast.

The ground made an odd sound as his shoe slid across it, drawing his eye back away from the wires again. The floor felt damp beneath his shoes. Not unusual, not really, but... *more* than usual. Glancing down, his foot gently rippled an inch, maybe two, of stagnant water; glossy and brown-green in the anemic light. It lay so still it had filmed over, surface tension tempering it into glass. His shoes had been sitting in it long enough that his socks were already damp at the heel. He somehow hadn't noticed. The walls seemed just as saturated, a faint sheen of moisture on the concrete like the whole room was slowly exhaling — and the scent that hung on everything was low and wet and old, mold and rust and something underneath both that he didn't have a name for. The air pressed in humid and hot, and one of the nearby pipes hissed like a living thing, sending steam drifting lazily through the room.

Was it always this...wet?

His breath went shallow for one beat, and then he smoothed it with reason. Basements flooded. Old buildings leaked. Pressure lines failed. The Entity was many things, but OSHA-compliant was not one of them. Though there had never been a leak like this before, he was sure of that. Even at it's worst, the preschool was run down and broken. Never... *moist*.

The overhead light buzzed, as if agreeing with his discomfort. It didn't flicker the way the lights usually did when a generator was running — that particular feedback was almost soothing by now, a sign that the work was registering. This was a flat, lazy drone, the light steady and somehow worse for it. The sickly light somehow managed to make everything look just a little bit off. Even the opening to the pipe hallway seemed to sit at the wrong angle.

Dwight glared at the hallway, generator forgotten as the wrongness seeped into his bones, his eyes snagging on a proportion that didn't resolve correctly no matter how long he looked at it. The doorframe was fine. The hallway beyond it was fine. But the relationship between them was off somehow, stretched or rotated by a degree or two in a direction that geometry didn't technically have a name for.

David didn't seem to notice. Or maybe he just didn't care. His entire frame was steady, eyes glued on his work, hands moving with the practiced ease of someone who had done this entirely too many times.

Dwight flexed his fingers and tried to keep working, but his eyes kept tracking the edges of the room. There were flickers in the lights of most trials, sure. Ambient smells and noises that were meant to set off nerves, naturally. Still...

There shouldn't be standing water. That part he was sure of. But when he squinted down, there it was: ripples, shallow and lazy. Maybe an inch, maybe more.

He was still trying to find the words for it, contemplating asking if David was noticing it too, when the pipe went.

The sound cracked through the basement like a gunshot — something rupturing deep in the hallway, a violent hiss of pressure releasing all at once — and David was on his feet before the echo died. A sharp inhale punched through his teeth as he spun, one hand shooting back as if to block Dwight, ready to fend off whatever was attacking. The pipe at the far end of the hallway was weeping a dark stain down the wall, and that was all. No attacker, no disaster.

Just a blown pipe.

He stood there for a beat, chest rising fast, then turned, half embarrassed, half bewildered, already opening his mouth to get Dwight back on task and hopefully not harassing him for being jumpy. He froze mid syllable at his teammate's expression.

Dwight wasn't looking at him.

He was still staring at the pipe hallway opening, the generator humming under his idle hands, with a stillness that made David's hair stand on end. Clearly the man had spotted something he had missed while trying to fight absolutely nothing? David followed his gaze, not seeing anything new, and turned back to the generator with an annoyed huff. This place was clearly getting to them both. Best to get the generator done and get back upstairs before their nerves went off even worse than they already are. Dwight was anxious to start with, and David was really not interested in that anxiety rubbing off on him right now.

"Hey. Earth to Dwight?"

Dwight blinked and looked away. "Sorry. Just... weird feeling."

He shifted his stance.

Slosh.

He looked down.

"...When the fuck did this place have a wading pool?"

The water lapped above the arch of his foot. It had soaked through his socks. Not just wet...murky. Almost oily. It caught what little light the buzzing overhead fixture offered, dark and absolutely still. How had he not noticed that? It wasn't very deep, but it was more than enough that he should have noticed while he was elbow deep in generator grease.

So how the fuck did he *MISS* that?

He took another look around the room, lightly clenching one fist in idle twitchiness from the mix of mold smell and the persistent heavy heartbeat thrum from the killer upstairs.

That was enough. There were other generators in other buildings and none of them were currently trying to give him a feeling he couldn't shake. They could leave this one to whoever else had pulled Bedham tonight and go find something less — whatever this was.

“Right. Nope. I’m out.” He backed away from the generator with abrupt finality. “Too wet. Too quiet. Too *weird*. I’m not getting trench foot for a basement gen. Back upstairs. We can go do one of the 2nd story house gens. You with me?”

Dwight blinked, pulled his attention back. “Yeah. Sorry.” He shook out his hands as if they’d gone numb. “We can do a different house. It’s—” He made a face. “—gross down here.”

“Gross I can do,” David said. “This is... extra.” He flicked a glance toward the stairs they’d come down. “Let’s try upstairs before it turns into any more of a sauna.”

He took a breath to ask if David felt it too, if the room was wrong, if he’d imagined the hallway getting longer; but David was already headed for the stairs. Dwight put a palm on the wall as he reached the bottom step, and the concrete felt warmer than it should have. Body-warm. He wiped his hand on his jeans and pretended the fabric hadn’t already stuck to his knee.

David made it partway up before slipping back into a crouch and pressing against the wall before the stairs bent to go up. Danny was sitting at the top, just above the landing. Phone in hand. Legs swinging lazily. Silently thumbing through an app like he was waiting for a bus. Not stealthed, not hunting — just *there*, in the worst possible place, with all the awareness of someone who had never seriously considered that anything might be coming up those stairs toward him.

David waved Dwight back, patting his chest quick and pointing up. Terror heartbeat straight ahead. Of course, the killer would be right there. It would be their luck that Danny had gotten bored with trashing the place and had settled in to play games on his phone for half a trial.

The boys shared a look, weighing options. The basement, with its wrong angles and weird light and inch of standing water, waited behind them. These stairs were clearly a no-go. That left the pipe hallway hole and the far back steps. The hole in the hallway ceiling wasn’t reachable from the ground, and even if they could scramble up to it, the hall it was in was directly down from the stairs. Trying to pass by Ghostface with a clear line of sight was a gamble at the best of times. Dude was entirely too quick and wily.

"Other stairs," David mouthed silently, jerking his chin towards the pipe hallway. Dwight nodded briskly and followed David into the mini-maze, only relaxing slightly when the terror radius calmed from a panicked hammering into a background thump, before fading away entirely.

The air in the hallway was worse; stale and wet and sharp, the kind of smell that curled behind your eyes. Pipes creaked above them, old and half-rotted. Twice, they had to duck surprise sprays of water as valves burst open in sharp, echoing snaps. The steam made the walls sweat. Dwight had almost immediately lost all sense of the room's geometry. The hallway had always been easy to get turned around in — he knew that, had been in it before — but something about the proportions felt wrong in a way that went beyond the usual tangle of valves and junctions. The walls were the right color, the pipes were the right rust, and somehow none of it added up to a space that felt like it should exist.

Valves hissed as they passed. One of them let out a sudden spray that soaked David's shoulder, making him flinch and swear again. "Didn't this used to be a lot shorter?"

"Layout changes," Dwight murmured, slightly relieved that it wasn't just him that had noticed. "It happens. The domains shift sometimes. Usually between trials, but..."

He trailed off, looking at the way the hallway kept going into the dark past the edge of what the light could reach. "*Usually* between trials."

"Yeah, well, I don't like this version."

There was no echo to their footfalls anymore. Just wet slaps swallowed by the space. David kept glancing at the pipes, brow furrowed in clear distrust, murmuring half to himself.

The second room was somehow worse than the first.

The water had found their ankles somewhere in the pipe hallway and followed them through, and by the time they cleared the last junction it was sitting just above — cool against the humid press of the air, which was somehow both damp and warm in a way that made no sense for a basement. The overhead light buzzed its flat, dying note. Dwight looked up, but the bulb wasn't flickering. It was just making that sound anyway, as it cast oddly angled shadows over the lockers that lined the wall.

The stairs were gone.

Not literally, but effectively. A wall of furniture had been shoved into the stairwell. Desks stacked against shelving units stacked against lockers, the whole mass of *stuff* settling into the stairwell opening like it had grown there. Some pieces looked warped. Wet. Some wedged. Some clearly just *tossed*. All crammed into the stairwell as if the building had tried to eat itself. The furniture was preschool sized mostly, but there was enough of it packed in that the combined weight was something else entirely. There was no space to squeeze through. No handholds. Overhead, the lone light in the ceiling dimmed with a jittery flicker before settling into its usual brightness.

"That's what he was doing," Dwight murmured, mostly to himself. The scraping sounds from upstairs when they first came in. Danny throwing things around. They'd assumed boredom. They hadn't been wrong, exactly.

David was already at the stack, shoulder against the nearest locker, pushing. The locker didn't move. He reset his footing and pushed harder. The furniture shifted — just slightly, a quarter inch of give — and then settled back exactly as it had been, as if the gap had never existed. David stared at it, dumfounded. Pushed again. Same result.

He tried a desk next, getting his fingers under the edge and hauling upward. The desk rocked once and came back down with a muffled sound that the air swallowed before it could properly echo, and David pulled his shoulder back with a sharp exhale, rolling it once.

"Brilliant. Just... great. The *hell* even IS this?"

"More importantly, how'd we not hear it? This should have made a ton of noise. We couldn't have been more than 50 feet away. Tops. I know the hallway eats sound in the corners, but there should have been *something*."

They tried to clear the stairs, pulling one chair, then another, but everything they dislodged seemed to drag more with it. Like the pile was *settling*, not shrinking. Several of the heavier pieces wouldn't budge at all. He took a breath and shoved again. The metal scraped, and the sound came out small, politely swallowed by the air. He stepped back with a scowl and flexed his fingers. Dwight tried a chair leg, then another, testing angles for leverage.

The sounds were wrong.

That was the thing that kept nagging at Dwight as the two worked methodically through their options — wrong in a specific, deliberate way. When David's shoulder connected with the locker, the impact made a sound that didn't carry. When the furniture shifted and settled back,

the scrape of it was swallowed before it could reach the walls. The basement should have been bouncing noise around, hard floors and concrete and all that pipe — instead everything just landed flat, absorbed, like the air itself had decided sound wasn't worth keeping.

Dwight stood in the water and listened to the silence eating itself for a moment longer. He almost mentioned it, then thought better of it. David already looked like he was getting annoyed with the stairway plug. Bringing up one more bit of weirdness in all this was not likely to land in his favor.

Dwight glanced back the way they came. "Should we go back? Danny gets bored easily; maybe he moved?"

David looked back at him over his shoulder, expression unreadable.

"Worth checking," Dwight murmured lightly, with slightly less conviction.

David nudged a shelf with his boot, barely listening, then hissed a breath through his teeth and shook his foot as if something in the water had touched him. "Nope. Don't like that."

Dwight looked through the mouth of the pipe hall again. The corridor lurched longer while he watched it — only a fraction, only the kind of shift you can blame on a blink. Looking back to try and get David's attention again, he noticed the stiffness in his shoulders and realized he had seen it too. The decision settled around them both. It was time to go. *Now*.

That was when the pipes screamed.

Somewhere deeper down the pipe hall, something ruptured — a sharp concussive crack followed immediately by a sustained shriek of pressure, the sound of it tearing through the basement — and both of them ducked on instinct, water soaking into clothing and rippling against random debris around them, Dwight's hands finding the nearest pipe junction, David crouched low with his arms thrown over his head, both of them braced for something that didn't come.

Steam burst out from a seam to their left and hit the ceiling in a white bloom that didn't disperse correctly. The bulb above them stuttered as if it had hiccupped on its own heat. Once. Twice. The third time, it simply failed, plunging the entire basement into an oppressive darkness.

The building held its breath.

Chapter Two – Floodline

Darkness fell and did not lift.

There was no flicker. No emergency backup. No lingering hum of standby power. One moment, the overhead light buzzed, warped and sickly, and the next, it was gone. The darkness just *was* — thick and absolute, a total absence that clung to their skin like wet cloth, pressing in from all sides until the two of them were just breathing in it and trying to remember where the walls were.

Dwight couldn't tell where his skin stopped and the world began. The water had reached his shins, warm in a way that felt wrong — closer to body temperature than anything a basement had a right to be.

A splash to his right; David swore under his breath, reaching out for something solid to orient himself, and caught his shoulder hard on a locker. The sound it made was flat and brief and immediately gone. The water sloshed violently at the impact, licking up Dwight's calves and soaking the fabric that hadn't already glued to him.

"You good?" Dwight called into the void.

"Peachy," David grunted. "Don't suppose you've got a light?"

Dwight patted his jacket, and his fingers bumped the slim cylinder tucked in the inside pocket. Relief buzzed through him. "Yeah — hang on—"

The flashlight slipped as he tried to pull it free, fingers fumbling, nerves not quite obeying. He caught it on the second grab and thumbed it on.

The beam sputtered.

Then held.

Barely.

It cast a cone of weak yellow light maybe a foot and a half ahead — just enough to see David's outline, slick with water and tension. The shadows pressed in thick around the edges, greedy and reluctant to let anything through.

"Better than nothing," he rubbed at his shoulder where he had caught it in the dark. "Goddamn lockers."

David turned toward the barricade, the light barely outlining the mess of desks and shelves still wedged into the stairwell.

"I'm not wandering blind," he said. "I'm gonna try moving this crap again. Just one desk. Just one fucking desk and I can climb over the rest."

He planted his feet in the water and shoved. The stack shifted and resettled. He shoved again. Same result. He worked his way along the pile, trying different points of leverage, each impact

swallowed before it could properly echo, the sounds dying the moment they left his hands like they were ashamed of themselves.

He very pointedly did not say anything about that.

“Fuck’s sake.”

He stepped back, kicked a locker. The metal thunk was dull. Muffled. Like it had been swallowed by insulation.

Dwight barely heard it. He was inching along the wall again, one hand trailing rust-damp metal as he backtracked toward the pipe hallway. The flashlight shivered in his grip as he swept it across the darkness.

He turned, slipping slightly as the water surged with his motion. He nearly dropped the flashlight. Caught it with both hands and steadied his breath.

David had both hands locked on a locker handle now, wrenching hard. Something groaned behind it but didn’t give.

“Why can’t I *hear* anything?” David muttered. “I’m making noise, I know I am.”

Dwight didn’t answer.

He was still staring at the water. The whole basement was dark, sure — but the water was *darker*, somehow. Not just murky. The light caught the surface and went nowhere, reflected back like the water had decided it wasn’t interested in being seen through.

Something grazed his shin.

He flinched hard, flashlight jerking up and sending spastic light darts along the ceiling.

He spun in place slowly, sweeping the beam down again. It barely cut the surface, but it was darker than it should have been. Murkier. It wasn’t just dirty — it was opaque, metallic, like it had decided reflection was another way out and sealed it. Like more than just rust was bleeding through the pipes.

Nothing there. Obviously, nothing there.

The water found his calves while he was still trying to convince himself of that. The beam barely penetrated an inch before giving up entirely, which was either a property of the water or a property of the flashlight, and he wasn't sure which option was worse.

The Nothing bumped his calf. Gentle. Almost curious.

His breath hitched.

"David?"

David didn't look up. He had both hands on a large desk, hauling upward with everything he had. The desk rocked — genuinely rocked this time, a real shift, the stack above it grinding with what sounded almost like progress — and then slid smoothly back into place as if he'd never touched it.

"David, I think there's something in the water," Dwight whispered.

David glanced back, shadowed eyes narrow. "Debris. Keep your head."

David gave the desk another shove. It rocked, then slid back into place as if correcting itself.

"Debris doesn't do that."

"I've nearly got it."

He didn't have it. Dwight could see that plainly. But David's jaw was set in the particular way it got when he'd decided something was happening through sheer force of will, and interrupting that with *there might be something in the water with us* was not a conversation Dwight felt equipped to have right now. David simply shoved the barricade again, muscles bunching under soaked cloth. Another scrape, another futile give. The water rippled outward and came back against them both.

The water had reached his knees at some point without Dwight noticing, the warmth of it creeping upward so gradually that his body had simply accepted it. Something grazed the inside of his knee — higher than before — and he locked every muscle in his body simultaneously, the flashlight beam skittering sideways as his hand jerked.

Nothing. Dark water. Pipes. His own heartbeat loud enough to hear.

Minutes — maybe longer — passed in the churn of their own breathing. The beam quivered between them like a nervous heartbeat.

Then the furniture groaned. A shelf slid down from the top of the pile and hit the water without a splash.

The air absorbed the sound.

—

The water was up to their waists when David finally gave up on the stairwell. The stack above David shifted, and a cascade of debris came down to fill the gap he'd made. He stepped back, breathing hard, and looked at his hands. Knuckles scraped raw. His shoulder had graduated from bruised to something more insistent. The stairwell stared back at him, unchanged and utterly indifferent to everything he'd put into it. A shelf tumbled down from the plug and landed with a wet *thud*, nearly hitting him.

"It's not giving," he spat, kicking one of the desks hard enough to jar his shin.

Dwight's light jittered across the walls. He tried not to look at the water anymore. He didn't want to see it.

"We should go back. Try the first stairs. At least those were open."

"Are you sure he's moved on?"

"No..." Dwight cast the beam into the pipe hall for a moment, shuddering lightly at the way the light seemed to be eaten in the distance. "But it's not like we can just stay here."

David gave a long, ragged sigh, finally stepping back from the mass of furniture like it had personally insulted him.

"Right," he sighed, mostly to himself, running a hand back through his hair as he looked around the small room. Dwight was doing his level best not to climb out of his own skin against the far wall. David filed that away and did the math.

Go back. Check if Danny had moved on. It was the sensible option — retrace through the pipe hallway, find the first room, see if the stairwell was clear. Simple. Logical. Except that the hallway had somehow doubled in length on their first pass through it, the flashlight had about as much range as a lit match, and the water was still rising with absolutely no indication that it intended to stop. Going back meant navigating all of that in the dark, on a maybe, with no guarantee that anything had changed.

It was clearly a bad idea. So was staying where they were and fighting with the immovable wall of furniture. Though...

"I mean..." he said, voice low and edged. "...there IS a plan B."

The sound of his boots dragging through the water was louder than the voice in his head telling him this was a bad idea. David scrubbed a hand through his hair, flicking water off his fingers in frustration.

Dwight hunched in on himself, flinching again as something bumped his calf for the umpteenth time. He didn't even bother to hiss a warning this time, just shot a glare into the shadows, flashlight beam jittering with the tremor in his hand.

"There's always the ceiling hole in the pipe hall."

Dwight stared at him like he'd been punched.

"The *pipe hall*?" His voice cracked. "We barely made it through the first time, and now it's half-flooded and pitch black. Getting past it is one thing, but you want to search it?! What if we miss the hole? What if it's *gone*?"

"It's not," David said, too quickly. Too certain.

"But..."

"Look, I don't like it either. But we don't really have time here. Plus, it's dark enough that we wouldn't be seen climbing out into the main hallway."

"David, it's almost 8 feet up! You might be able to climb that..."

Dwight froze as a look of tense guilt washed over David. In a heartbeat, he realized what David was hinting at.

“You want to wait out the flood. Let the water get us up there.”

Dwight watched his jaw tense as he turned his eyes away. It was a bad decision, clearly. But so was everything else. If Ghostface was still at the other stairs, they wouldn't see him in time. If they kept trying at these stairs, they would lose precious time needed to search the pipe hallway. Assuming they DID find the hole, they would need to wait out the rising water in the dark. No option felt good, but at least the ceiling hole had less chance of getting them stabbed.

Dwight looked at the water sitting dark and patient at his waist, and felt something cold move through him regardless.

“God, I hate that that might actually work.”

David didn't press when Dwight hesitated at the corridor, flashlight already trembling in his hand. He knew what was waiting there. They both did. But at the rate the water was rising, they were running out of time to debate routes.

The pipe hallway had grown.

There was no other explanation for it — the junctions multiplying, familiar valves appearing in unfamiliar arrangements, the walls presenting corners that hadn't existed on the first pass. The flashlight beam caught pipes and more pipes and the occasional burst of weirdly neutral-temperature spray as something gave way overhead, hosing them down without warning before the pressure died and the dark closed back in.

The flashlight's beam cut through the dark like a scalpel, but even in the narrow corridors it was weak. Sickly yellow and wavering, barely enough to outline the pipe-laced walls. Water was already brushing along their ribs now. For Dwight, it felt like it was pulling at him, rising along his stomach with a patient claiming. The water lower down tugged at his ankles lightly, a surreal current leading nowhere that felt determined to pull him away from the walls and back into the darkness.

He wasn't cold. Not really. But he still shook so badly he could hardly keep the light straight. It flickered against the walls as if it was afraid too. Every few steps, something slapped or hissed beside them, busted pipes still spewing from unseen seams. It felt personal. Like the building itself was spitting on them for trespassing.

David squinted against it, pushing forward with grim determination. The floor was harder to grip as the water level rose, his own buoyancy making his feet slide slightly with every step.

Every pipe they brushed against sent shivers up his spine. To his side, Dwight stumbled and nearly fell. David grabbed his arm without looking. The man may have been taller than him, but he was significantly less stable on his feet.

Something brushed against Dwight's leg again — lower, almost playful in its angle — causing a high sound that he hadn't meant to make.

He jolted. The flashlight spun. Water slapped. "David—"

"Yeah, I feel it too." David muttered. "Just keep moving."

They turned another corner. Somehow it was the same corner as the last one.

It *had* to be.

"I think we're going in circles..."

"No. We're not. The pipes — look — they're different here."

They weren't. Neither man would admit it. They just adjusted their direction and pushed on.

From somewhere above, the pipes hissed—and with a heavy thump, a jet of water slammed down like a burst fire hose into Dwight's back, driving him into the wall. The flashlight went under for a second. He scrambled to fish it up off the floor, coughing as he surfaced.

"Dwight!"

"I'm fine!" It was half-truth, but he forced himself to believe it anyways.

The light flicked back on just in time to see the hallway stretch again. The corridor behind them looked longer than before, the corner they had just turned already swallowed up in the dark. Dwight pushed water-soaked hair back from his face and steadied himself, pushing on to follow David down the hallway.

And behind them, the water followed. Slow. Steady. Inevitable.

The second-floor hallway was dry.
Mostly.

A few dark puddles gleamed near the warped window frames, but it hadn't reached *here* yet.
Not enough to matter.

Danny lounged on the upper landing with all the practiced sprawl of a bored cat; one knee hooked over the balustrade and the other braced against the cracked drywall like a king surveying his flooded kingdom.

His phone was in his hand, angled down, its screen throwing a faint glow up against his mask. His robes pooled around him, dry and settled, the long straps gently fluttering around him, as if She was enjoying the show by his side.

Below him, the school was doing something genuinely impressive.

He'd seen Her work before. Watched domains shift, watched geometry go quietly wrong in ways that took survivors too long to notice. But this was more deliberate than usual — the hallways stretching, the furniture piling itself well beyond the random junk he'd tossed down the stairs earlier, the water rising with that particular patient quality of something that had already decided how this ended and was just filling in the middle parts. She was definitely enjoying Herself tonight. That much was obvious.

On the feed, a grainy-green lens tracked the survivors below. The RC submarine had been an impulse purchase — spotted in a novelty shop in someone's memory of a boardwalk, bought on the vague suspicion that it might be funny someday. He hadn't anticipated *how* funny. The camera he'd rigged to it wasn't anything special, cheap night vision that turned everything a washed-out green, but it was picking up every inch of Dwight Fairfield flinching away from something he couldn't see as he circled the man's ankles like a curious shark, and that was frankly more than enough.

The camera feed swayed with the current, too slow to track at first, until it *bumped* into something.

He flicked the rudder, turned the camera angle, and watched as Dwight jumped again — probably thought he felt a *tail*.

Danny snorted softly into the darkness.

“Fucking priceless.”

He zoomed in, casually, as Dwight flailed sideways into the wall, barely muffling his own shout. Every kick, every flail, every panicked gasp was caught on film. Poor quality, sure, but the *emotions* read clear. Fear didn’t need 4K.

“*Welcome back to Night Watch,*” he murmured to no one, the corners of his mouth twitching in amusement.

“I’m your host, Danny 'Fuck Around and Find Out' Johnson. Let’s check in on our contestants.”

He stretched a little, back cracking. Took a lazy look down the hall through his phone’s own camera. The school was twisting all on its own now. He didn’t need to chase them. Didn’t need to do anything, really — She had renovated the entire school into something these two were never getting out of on their own, and all he had to do was sit here and document the experience. He even had night vision mode on his phone for if they eventually made it upstairs. He had footage already that was genuinely some of his best work. And somewhere below him, in the dark and the rising water, Dwight Fairfield was standing very still and trying very hard not to make any noise about whatever had just grazed his knee.

He adjusted the camera angle one more time, getting a better view of the pipe hallway, and settled back against the wall with a comfortable sigh.

Easiest trial he’d had in years.

No knives today. No hooks.

Just patience, petty vengeance, and a camera. And eventually, he would wander back to his safe spot for the night with a fantastic new film for his collection, while the Entity rested from the finest meal she’s had in ages.

He adjusted the angle with a lazy finger flick and watched the chaos bloom below like algae, murky, aimless, choking.

Chapter Three: Surface Tension

The water had risen to their shoulders, making forward progress a tense, miserable slog. Dwight kicked gently to keep his head above the surface, the motion strange and clumsy. kept one hand on the pipes running along the wall, using them to pull himself forward against the current rather than fight it directly. It was slow, but it was the only thing keeping him upright. He was tall enough to stay grounded if he really stretched, but David wasn't so lucky — the man was full-on treading water, eyes narrowed in concentration as he tried to keep from bumping into any more unseen furniture drifting beneath them.

The current tugged at Dwight's legs, lazy and persistent, and his jacket clung to him like a wet towel, dragging him down. Every stroke felt heavier. Slower. The pockets were sodden, and the soaked fabric pulled at his arms as he reached for the pipes lining the walls, trying to orient himself.

"This is stupid," he muttered, breath ragged. "This is *so* stupid."

He reached for another pipe — nearly missed — and yanked himself sideways just in time to avoid colliding with a floating end-table. He grabbed the next pipe junction, steadied himself, and noticed that he was slower than he'd been ten minutes ago. Slower and lower. Somewhere behind him, David grunted. The sound was swallowed a little by the dark, but still audible.

The flashlight's beam — barely hanging on — flickered again as it caught on the edge of a floating chair, then skipped off into empty space.

Something bumped against Dwight's thigh.

He didn't scream. Couldn't. His breath locked down hard in his chest, throat clenched. The water tugged at his legs with the slow pull of an undertow that didn't belong in a hallway. He reached for a pipe, any pipe, his fingers scrabbling against wet metal.

Another tug.

The weight of his jacket had become unbearable. It sucked at his arms, pulled his body down, soaked cloth clinging against his skin. He gasped and fumbled with the zipper, yanking the jacket loose and letting it drift free in the water. It wasn't that much of a loss — the Fog would return it at the campfire like everything else the survivors left behind — but he still felt exposed without it.

The ceiling was maybe 2 feet above the water now, maybe less, the space between the surface and the plaster shrinking steadily. He kept his eyes on it anyway — not that looking helped, the flashlight beam barely reaching the pipes directly ahead of them — and tried not to think about what it meant that he could feel the cold air on the top of his head.

The flashlight buzzed. The bulb flickered, dimmed, flared again like it was coughing. It had never been good, but the periodic submersions had taken something fundamental out of it — the beam guttering now when it should have held steady, throwing the ceiling into shadow for a half second at a time before catching again. Dwight held it above the surface as much as he

could manage, which wasn't always, and every time it went under, he felt the weight of the dark press in a little closer.

He was starting to lose track of where the hole should be.

The hallway had shifted so much from its original shape that nothing lined up anymore — no landmark he'd clocked on the first pass was where he expected it to be, and the ceiling above them was uniform and featureless in the failing beam. What if She'd closed it? What if the geometry had swallowed it entirely, the way it had swallowed the extra distance and the extra junctions and the logic of the space itself?

Dwight shook off the thought, blinked hard and adjusted the angle. He had been sweeping the ceiling in slow arcs, watching the plaster slide past in the weak yellow light, when the texture changed — torn edges framing a gap that swallowed the beam entirely, a circle of absolute black that stretched the full width of the hallway above them.

“There!” he shouted, voice cracking with hope and desperation. “There it is!”

David looked up with a half-relieved laugh just as the flashlight gave its last pathetic breath. A final, stuttering flick of yellow that haloed the hole for barely a second...

And died.

The dark swallowed them.

No noise. No light. Just breath and water and the dizzying pressure of a space that no longer wanted them.

“Shit – no no no...” Dwight shook the flashlight, trying to will it back to life. The current dragged at his hips and his elbow hit a pipe, the flashlight popping free of his grasp and lazily drifting towards the floor.

“Dwight?”

“I’ve got it! I—”

He flailed, slipped under for a second, and broke the surface again coughing. David's hand found his collar and hauled him back up, hard enough to hurt.

“You *don’t* got it,” David snapped.

"I'm fine," Dwight choked out, blinking water from his eyes. He could still *see* the hole in his mind — could still remember the angle — but now there was only black. "David, the light - I can't..."

"Just leave it! Come on. The hole was right there. Feel around! It spanned the whole hallway. It's not like we can *miss* it."

Dwight tipped his head back. The ceiling was right there — he could feel the cold air against his face, barely a foot of space between the water's surface and the plaster. He reached up and his fingers found it immediately.

Dwight hesitated in the dark for a moment before slamming his palm against the ceiling, clinging to the pipes on the wall for stability as the two scrambled down the hall towards where they had last seen the edge.

They moved by touch, hands flat against the ceiling, the current tugging at their legs with that same gentle insistence that had followed them through the whole hallway. Dwight counted his strokes. Fifteen feet, maybe less. They'd seen it. It was right there.

The ceiling slid under his palms, unbroken and smooth, telling him nothing.

—

They went under together.

One moment there was still an inch of air, the cold plaster brushing the tops of their heads, and then there wasn't — the surface closing the last gap with a quiet finality. No rush. No drama. Just the ceiling arriving, and the space gone, and the dark complete in every direction at once.

The current had been waiting for exactly this — the moment neither of them had a surface to orient by — and it pulled with more confidence now, a slow lateral drag that had no interest in where they wanted to go. He kept one hand on the ceiling, pulling himself forward through the dark, counting his strokes the way he'd been counting since the flashlight died. The hole had been fifteen feet ahead, maybe less. He'd seen it. He knew where it was.

At some point he realized he couldn't feel David anymore.

Not a dramatic separation — no collision, no moment of loss. Just the gradual awareness that the presence he'd been tracking by sound and movement and the occasional brush of an arm had gone quiet, and the vibrations in the water were coming from somewhere he couldn't locate, muffled and directionless in the dark. He swept a hand out to the side and found nothing but water.

Dwight didn't mean to lose track of him. But the bizarre current, however slow it seemed, tugged him just wrong. Or maybe it was panic. Maybe it was the weight of soaked clothes and adrenaline twisting his limbs. One moment he was kicking toward the shape in the ceiling, lungs burning, hands scraping slick surfaces.

The next, he was alone.

Water above. Water below. No direction. No light. No grip. The water crawled into every seam of skin and clothing like a living thing. It pulsed in Dwight's sinuses, hissed in his ears, beat against his ribcage with an endless roar.

Panic surged. Dwight's lungs seized. He forced himself not to inhale, not to kick too hard. He stayed close to the ceiling, one hand pressed flat against it, working along by feel alone. Plaster. Tile. Seam. Crack. Pipe—

Nothing.

Every sound dissolved into the water, tunneling awareness into vague thumps and creaks just out of range.

A thud rolled through the water, metal on metal, distant. He twisted, bubbles clawing free from his throat.

Another vibration, swallowed so fully it was more pressure than sound, rippling along his ribs. It might've been David. Might've been the pipes screaming again. He couldn't tell.

A pipe materialized where the hallway shouldn't have had one, catching his shoulder and spinning him partway around. He found the ceiling again and reoriented, except he wasn't certain anymore which direction he'd come from. The current pushed at his legs from a new angle. Something moved in the water nearby — too large to be debris, too deliberate — and

grazed the back of his calf with the particular patience of something that had been following him for a while.

Dwight kicked hard, arms scrabbling against walls that weren't where they should be. His brain screamed *up!* but his body spun, panic shredding orientation until he didn't know which way he was moving. The flashlight had been a compass, however weak, and now it was gone.

Pressure gnawed at his ears. His chest locked, ribs straining for breath that wasn't there. His vision prickled at the edges, the rising stars of a blackout dancing with every frantic movement.

Something brushed past his leg again. Not a graze this time. Not the lazy curious arc of something circling. This was deliberate — a solid nudge against his calf that sent a shock of pure animal panic up his spine, and his body reacted before his brain could intervene. He jerked, twisting, bubbles tearing from his nose in a strangled choke, and for one disorienting heartbeat, he was sure there *wasn't* a surface. Just water forever.

His knuckles struck tile. Then hit a ridge. Broken ceramic. Something hard and sharp and... *right*.

He clawed upward, fingers catching, dragging.

His arms caught the edge of something, and he *pulled*. Up. *Up*. Some kind of splinter tore skin from his palm. His whole body surged, slamming shoulder-first into the gap.

The world detonated.

His throat ripped open around the first savage gasp, water and air fighting for space. He broke the surface gagging, hacking, shuddering so hard his knees buckled the instant he scrambled onto the sodden tiles. He curled onto his side, heaving, spit and floodwater streaming out of him in trembling bursts.

He coughed until his ribs ached. Pressed his forehead to the floor. Breathed.

The hallway was dark and quiet except for the soft lap of water against the edges of the hole behind him.

Just the water. Just his shaking breaths.

Dwight allowed the cool tiles to hold him, boneless, limbs jittering with aftershock. Relief hit sharp and dizzying; he'd found it, he was out, he was alive. He allowed himself to simply breathe against the cold tiles for a time. It took a minute to realize he was the only one doing so.

He twisted back toward the hole, horror seizing his gut like a vice. "...David?" The sound cracked, raw, too small for the drowned dark. Nothing answered but the slap of water against ceiling.

The tile was cold against his palms and his chest heaved and the water ran off him in thin streams and he waited for the sound of David breaking the surface behind him. Hands finding the edge. The grunt of effort. Something.

The water lapped softly at the edges of the hole. It hadn't even been that long, but David wasn't there. The water churned quietly below him, but no head broke the surface. No splashing. No sign.

His head buzzed from the pressure knotting in his chest. David had been *right there*. Right beside him. One selfish beat, he thought of staying out, curling in the puddle and pretending David would follow. His body screamed for it. *He'll be right behind you*. The thought came with the exhaustion, easy and warm and almost convincing. *Just rest. Just breathe. He's coming*.

Dwight lay on the tile a moment more and breathed and listened to the silence.

Then moved back to the hole.

He found it by feel, fingers trailing across tile until the edge dropped away, and reached into the water up to his shoulder. Nothing. He swept his arm in a slow arc, searching, hoping to catch a fistful of sleeve, hair, something. Anything. The gentle tug of the current wrapped around his wrist, providing nothing in return.

A swirl of movement shifted gently against the back of his hand and he leaned further in, focusing on the current. It wasn't the same kind of tug on his skin. This felt focused — a deliberate movement rather than the flow that had knocked him around in the hallway.

David's close — Dwight realized in an instant — but he's off course. The same current that tried to steal Dwight is dragging David too, just far enough to miss the exit. He was *lost*.

The silence of the hallway pressed in expectantly. Like the floor was holding its breath, waiting to see if he'd move. Dwight swore he could hear the distant *tick* of settling tile, the whisper of water threading under the walls. The hole gently sloshed against his arm, simply waiting.

He wasn't going to find the edge. Dwight would have guide him. That meant going back in. He squeezed his eyes shut against the darkness, steeling himself as best he could, every nerve shrieking. He sucked one more shuddering breath and dove, black water swallowing him whole.

It was so much worse the second time. His muscles were jelly, lungs scalded raw. Each stroke felt a half-second too slow. He swept his arms wide, blind, hands rasping pipe and plaster, mentally mapping the way back. The water pressure slammed into his body like a second impact, stealing the little air he had left. But he pushed through it, arms out, kicking hard. He followed the flow, felt for resistance. The movement was stronger now — more urgent, less controlled — and he knew what that meant. He'd been in enough trials to know what David panicking felt like. The movement thrashed ahead, strong, furious, off course. Dwight lunged, hand snagging *something*.

Fabric. Arm.

Elbow.

The flail that followed would've knocked his teeth in if not for the drag of the water. He pulled. David pulled back on reflex, wrong direction, and Dwight held on and redirected, hand over hand up David's arm until he had him by the collar and could haul him bodily toward the ceiling.

They surfaced together in a mess of limbs and swearing.

David gasped like someone being born again, hair plastered to his face, arm curling tight against Dwight's as they clawed for the edge. This time, it was David who found the lip, muscling them both up and over in a final, sodden scramble.

They got out.

That was the only thought Dwight's brain could hold for a while — the simple, enormous fact of tile under his hands and air above his head, real air, not a shrinking inch of it with water pressing in from below. He stayed down, pressed tight against solid ground, and coughed until

his chest ached and then kept coughing anyway, because his lungs had opinions about the last several minutes and they were going to be heard.

Somewhere beside him, David was doing the same.

For a long, long moment, they didn't move.

Then David started laughing.

For half a second, Dwight couldn't tell if it was actually laughter or sobbing. His ears were still ringing from the silence below, and the sound scraped like a blade across bruised nerves.

The deep hiccups of laughter broke the silence with a wheezing, exhausted lilt — helpless and a little broken at the edges and contagious in the specific way that delirious relief always was. Somehow, that made it real. They'd made it. Barely.

Dwight answered with a grunt and flopped sideways on the cold tile, absolutely spent.

"Next time," David gasped through rawed-out chuckles, "you lead."

"Next time," Dwight muttered, "I stay upstairs."

—

THWACK.

Dwight let out a sharp yelp of pain as something solid smacked into the side of his head. He blinked, vision swimming, catching a blur of movement and a sharp gasp and the scrape of boots on tile as whoever had hit him scrambled backward. A beam of light swung across them — strong and bright and absolutely blinding after hours of nothing — and Dwight threw an arm up against it, eyes watering.

"Oh my god—" A voice. Female. Familiar. "Oh my god, I'm so sorry, I didn't see you, I almost—"

David hissed and tried to turn away from the light, entirely too bright after all the darkness.

The light veered quickly to one side with a trail of apologies, finally letting Dwight's eyes adjust enough to see Orela — wild-eyed, nearly having walked straight into the hole they'd just escaped, were it not for the sudden human speed bump in the way.

"Holy fuck," Dwight choked, rubbing his eyes with a groan. *"Warn a guy before kicking his brain back into his skull..."*

"Oh my god, I didn't see you!" Orela stooped to help Dwight sit up. *"We thought we heard something so I was just...how did you even get in here? What happened?"*

David coughed out another laugh. *"Spent some time in the school's new waterpark. I don't recommend it."*

Orela helped Dwight to sit upright, frowning as swept the flashlight over the two of them, taking in their state fully for the first time, soaked and wheezing on the floor. The beam passed over the hole and froze as realization sank in.

"You guys were downstairs this whole time?"

The three of them sat there, blinking in the flashlight glare, dripping onto the hallway floor as the silence of the preschool returned.

Orela stared at the hole for a moment longer than was strictly necessary.

The water lapped softly at its edges, dark and patient, like it was waiting to see if anyone else was going to come back for it.

"Right," she said, in the tone of someone filing several things away to process later. She crouched down and got a hand under Dwight's arm, helping him upright. He came up slowly, waterlogged and unsteady.

"Sorry about your head," she said.

"S'fine," Dwight managed. It wasn't entirely fine. But it was fine enough.

David got himself up without assistance through what appeared to be sheer principle, made it to vertical, and stayed there through an act of will that Orela clocked but didn't comment on. She cast one last look at the hole in the floor before turning away.

The three of them moved off into the dark of the hallway, wet footsteps marking the tile behind them.

Behind them, the water lapped quietly at the edge of the hole. Rising, still. Patient as anything.

Chapter Four – Echo Chamber

The classroom Orela led them to was small even by the school's original standards — low desks, scattered toys, cabinets with chipped paint. It looked ordinary enough. That was almost worse.

The school she'd navigated to find them bore almost no resemblance to the building they'd entered. Hallways that should have been thirty feet were closer to a hundred. Classrooms had multiplied, doors appearing in walls that hadn't had them before, the whole structure spreading outward and inward simultaneously like something organic. The Entity had renovated thoroughly and without apology, and the result was something that had stopped pretending to make sense. Shadows clung too tight in the corners. The walls didn't meet right. The beam from the flashlight couldn't quite seem to settle anywhere useful, making everything feel ever so slightly like a fever dream.

Orela had apparently been with the rest of the survivors, only venturing out when the group had heard the boys make their miraculous resurgence into the land of the semi-dry, nearly walking straight into the hole they had just escaped from in the process. Limping into the classroom, the boys found Leon and Jake waiting in the dark, looking confused and more than a little surprised in the thin flashlight beam.

David slumped heavily into the chair at the teacher's desk, arms braced, eyes locked on a far point in the floor that he wasn't really seeing. Water still clung to him in rivulets, pooling at his feet as his clothes dripped a slow, steady rhythm.

Orela crouched beside him, flashlight angled low as she tried gauging his pupils without blinding him further.

"You're gonna crash," she murmured. "Your system's still in full burn. You need to rest."

"Not yet," David muttered, not looking at her. "Don't have time. I'll be fine."

He wasn't fine. She could see that easily enough — the way he held his shoulder slightly wrong, the controlled quality of his breathing that meant he was managing something he wasn't acknowledging. He'd been in the water long enough and worked hard enough that the consequences were coming whether he cooperated or not.

He knew it too. That was the problem.

His heart was still hammering like it hadn't realized the danger was over. His lungs ached, raw and tight. The skin over his back twitched with ghost-water, nerves refusing to settle. He could still feel the moment Dwight found him, how everything slowed, muffled, his thoughts collapsing inward. There hadn't been enough air in the world.

He refused to feel that again.

But beneath the desk, his legs betrayed him, shaking faintly, despite how still he sat. His shoulder throbbed. Probably from ramming it into that desk in the stairwell. Or maybe from hauling Dwight by the arm like a sack of potatoes through a hallway that shouldn't have existed. His spine pulsed with delayed adrenaline. Every second he didn't move, he was losing ground.

If he stopped pushing, stopped performing functional — the thing he'd been holding at arm's length since they'd clawed out of that hole was going to catch up with him. If he fell, he wasn't sure he'd get back up.

Orela sighed, casting the beam toward the door. The hallway stretched beyond it in flickering shadow, and for now, nothing stirred.

Leon lingered near the door, glancing down the corridor with one hand on his empty holster. His shoulders twitched. There was a tightness in his movements — familiar tension, the darkness having set off a well worn in paranoia he couldn't shake.

Dwight had folded himself onto one of the low children's desks, shoulders slumped from the weight of the ordeal. His clothes were soaked, his face drawn. The adrenaline was draining fast, leaving him hollow and shaking. He looked vacant, but his hands gripped the edge of the desk tight, feet planted firm on the ground as if trying to anchor himself. He wasn't shaking anymore, not visibly, but the stillness had a quality to it that wasn't calm. His eyes tracked the room without settling on anything.

Jake was perched on the counter, slamming the straight end of a half-rusted crowbar against the window. The glass refused to shatter, absorbing each strike with a soundless thud. He cursed under his breath and gave it a final smack before hopping off the counter.

"This is insane. It's not even tempered glass. What the hell is this place MADE of?"

David turned his head to face him. "How long have you three been up here, anyways?"

"Been in here half an hour, maybe more," Jake said, prying at the frame. "Thought it was just us and Orela. Doors started showing up everywhere and closed up behind us. Like the building didn't want anyone else in. Feels like the place has doubled in size since we got in"

Orela nodded in agreement, gesturing around the classroom with the flashlight. "Classrooms repeat. Some of them shift. I chalked it up to the usual Entity bullshit, but..."

Dwight lifted his head slightly. "You guys got doors, we had faulty plumbing. Pipes were bursting. Something's wrong with the space."

Leon's brow furrowed. "Like... what?"

"Distances felt off. Sounds vanished. Water rose faster than it should've. Way faster." He swallowed. "It wasn't just leaking. It was... flooding. Like it was pushing it through the floor. Way more than broken pipes should have had."

He kept his voice even and mostly managed it, though his hands tightened on the edge of the desk while he talked.

"How fast?"

Dwight hesitated. "Up to our ribs in minutes."

David grunted. "Hit the ceiling before we made it halfway down the connecting hallway."

He spared a glance at Dwight, who had gone back to curling against himself, voice soft. "It was so disorienting. Nothing was where it should have been. We lost my flashlight at some point... I had to go back to drag David out."

Leon nodded once, his hand clenched at his side, reflexive. A muscle twitched in his jaw. He looked down at the floor — to the thin spread of water that Dwight and David had tracked in with them, pooling dark against the tile — and he took one step to the side, away from the puddle he'd been standing in, without appearing to notice he'd done it.

Jake looked around slowly, then back to the windows. "Weird that there's five of us."

Orela blinked. "What?"

Jake gestured vaguely with the butt of his crowbar. "There's usually four, yeah? But with these two showing up together, that means it's been five since the start."

"Trials run four survivors," he continued, looking around the group. "Four survivors, four generators, two gates. The whole thing's built around even numbers. So." He gestured vaguely at all of them. "Five."

Nobody had a good answer for that. Dwight's brows furrowed and he blinked slowly, the words catching something half-formed in his mind. He couldn't quite place why, but something about it itched at him. Huffing lightly, he shook the feeling off. It was probably just the dark — the claustrophobia of it all.

Orela had moved on to resume checking David's shoulder, unable to stay still in the silence anymore. David submitted to approximately four seconds of this before shifting away from her hands with an absent swat.

"Stop it. I'm fine."

"You're holding your arm like it's going to fall off."

"It's not that bad. It'd feel better if you'd stop poking at it."

Dwight watched the flashlight beam move around the room as Orela gestured, unwilling to lose track of the only light in the room. Every dip and bounce made his chest tighten. As she drifted around, fussing over an increasingly annoyed David, her steps disturbed the floor, making it ripple slightly.

It took a moment to see it properly.

Not floor.

A film of water threading across the tiles.

Dwight hissed and yanked his legs up on the desk before he'd finished processing what he'd seen — crouched, both hands white-knuckled on the edges — and the sound that came out of him was closer to a startled animal than a person.

"No no nonono, David..."

David turned, saw his face, followed his eyes. "Fuck..."

He tried to stand, grip tight against the desk edge, only for his legs to fold like wet paper.

Orela surged forward, catching him under one arm on reflex, nearly going down with him. He was heavier than he looked, all soaked muscle and bone and adrenaline backlash.

"I've got it," He pulled his arm free, righting himself and stepping back from her, knees buckling slightly as he righted himself. "Said m'fine."

The water was there. A thin skin of it across the tile, barely a shimmer, running in from the hallway as quietly and patiently as everything else the building had done tonight.

Dwight was already hunched in on himself, visibly shrinking from the puddle, a steady quiet stream of "not again" drifting on near hyperventilation as Leon rubbed small circles on his back. Panicking was not going to help things.

"Hey. You're okay. It's not the basement. We can figure it out. We have time."

Dwight's knuckles were white on the desk edge, his breathing coming in shallow pulls that weren't quite keeping up with demand. His eyes had gone to the floor and stuck there, tracking the thin skin of water like it might lunge.

"I know," he said. "I know, I just—"

"I know," Leon kept his tone low, not following his gaze down.

"We need to move." David's voice cut across the room, flat and certain. He was already looking at the door. "If it's still coming in, we don't have time to sit here."

"Go where, exactly?" Jake snapped from the counter, "Windows won't break. I've been at this for twenty minutes. Whatever this glass is, it doesn't want to shatter. And we've struck out on the doors already."

"Blocked like the stairs?" David asked.

Jake and Leon shared a look. "Stairs?"

"Ghostface blocked us in. Plugged up one of the stairwells with random crap. That's why we had to go through the pipe hall. I think he's still—"

"Wait, he's here?" Orela moved to hold David's elbow again and only stepping back when he shot her a look full of steel and defiance.

Dwight was trying to calm his breathing, to varying levels of success, redirecting his mind forcibly from the floor to literally anything else. "Didn't you guys see him? He wasn't even hiding when we came in. He was making a ton of noise."

"We didn't hear it," Jake looked down at the crowbar in his hand, thoughtful. "Actually, we've heard almost nothing this whole time. Building eats everything."

Orela shook her head, confused. "There hasn't been any kind of killer terror radius in here that we've felt. I had no idea he was even in this area. We had assumed whatever killer was assigned this trial got left outside."

"Besides," Jake swung at the window one more time, crowbar bouncing harmlessly off, "The doors aren't locked or blocked up. They're jammed. The handles move fine, but the frame is swollen and warped so bad that the doors won't budge."

Leon shared a meaningful glance with David and nodded. "That was when I was trying with Jake. With David, we have more muscle now. Between the three of us, we might be able to pry one of them open. What do you say? Feel up for a break and exit?"

David looked at his shoulder. Rolled it once, deliberately. Took a couple steps, mentally logging the way his knees wobbled. The wince was small and controlled. He was steady enough for now. It would have to do.

"Yeah. Ok. Let's give it a go."

Orela swung her flashlight toward the hallway. The beam sliced the dark like a knife, catching on dust and soaked linoleum. "Let's get out of here before the place decides we're not interesting enough to keep."

In the hush that followed, Dwight kept his eyes on the floor. The water had reached the back wall. A thin layer, barely enough to splash — but moving. It was seeping in, quietly, purposefully. A slow reclaiming.

Behind them, the walls pulsed. Just slightly. Jake glared at it with clear suspicion.

The decision made itself, really. The front door had been the first thing Leon and Jake had tried and it was worth trying again with the full group behind it. Failing that, there were other exits. They'd work through them in order until something gave.

The group filed out into the hallway, Orela's flashlight leading.

Somewhere in the dark behind them, just outside the beam's reach, a shape kept pace.

Danny tucked his phone into his sleeve and melted backward into the dark, footsteps silent despite the water — it had climbed past his ankles while he wasn't paying attention, which was mildly annoying, and his robes dragged through it with the heavy, sodden pull of fabric that had given up trying to stay dry. The long straps floated around him, trailing dark patterns across the surface. He'd have to do something about the mold smell later. The leather was going to hold it for weeks if he didn't treat it properly, and the canvas underlayer was probably already past saving if he was being honest with himself.

Later problem.

Right now, the beam of Orela's flashlight was painting the group in sharp relief — five people, wet and tired and moving with the grim purpose of survivors who had run out of other options — and he had a camera, a clear angle, and absolutely no intention of missing a single moment of what came next.

He adjusted his position, keeping to the dark at the edge of the beam, and watched the rats work the maze.

Ch 5 – Under Pressure

The water lapped around their ankles with gentle, steady persistence.

The hallway stretched longer than it had any right to as the group worked their way through, five shadows in single file, led only by the beam of Orela's flashlight. The air hung heavy around them, thick with dampness and the sour rot of slow decay, clinging damp and thick to the inside of their throats. It felt unnatural. *Processed*. Rancid. Recycled through old pipes and bleeding walls.

Every breath felt humid. Every movement whispered. The floor felt soft in places, like the linoleum had given up beneath the rising tide.

The creeping flood found their calves before they'd made it halfway down the hall.

Nobody announced it. Nobody needed to. It was just suddenly there, cool and present against skin that had almost — *almost* — dried out in the classroom, and the group absorbed the information in their own individual silences.

Here we go again.

That was the sum total of what Dwight's nervous system had to say about the situation, delivered with the flat certainty of something that had already been through this once tonight and had not enjoyed it. He kept his eyes forward and his breathing measured and his hands away from the walls because touching the walls meant feeling how damp they were, and feeling how damp they were meant thinking about where that moisture was coming from, and that was a thought he wasn't ready to finish.

His footsteps stuttered through the water. Not enough to call attention, but enough to tell. His gaze kept flicking between the others, fingers twitching at his side. Five. That number had been pinging something at the back of his brain since Jake said it aloud. Five survivors. Five people. One too many.

There was never supposed to be five.

He couldn't explain it, didn't have the words for what it meant, but he felt it under his skin like a splinter. The Entity's work was always symmetrical. Ritualistic. Four survivors. Four ways back to the campfire. Two exits. Balance was how the Fog functioned. Five was *off*. Five was *bait*. He didn't see the water creeping higher anymore. Didn't see the shadows moving differently. He saw numbers. Patterns. Ratios. He was spiraling inward like a whirlpool, understanding just barely out of reach.

David limped alongside Dwight — jaw set, shoulders square, vision narrowed down to the hallway's vanishing point. He was trying not to cough, breath kept shallow as he focused on the next few steps. If he kept his focus locked on the exit and ignored the pull of the water around his calves, maybe he wouldn't feel how soft his knees had gotten. He desperately needed to rest. He could feel it behind his eyes, but he shelved it.

Later. He could fold later.

Once they were out.

Leon kept his eyes on the middle distance. Not the floor. Definitely not the floor. Dwight's warning about the water rising faster than natural echoed in his head like a drip. Ribs in minutes. Ceiling in under half an hour. He knew what that kind of pressure felt like, lungs too tight, world flipping upside down.

He'd looked at the floor once, briefly, when the water was still just a shimmer across the tile back in the classroom, and something in the back of his brain had pulled up a memory he hadn't asked for — dark lake water, the specific pressure of something large moving beneath him — and he'd slammed the door on it before it could finish the sentence. He was fine. The hallway was flooded, not a lake. Completely different. He kept his eyes up.

The memory knocked again, politely, and he ignored it.

Jake hadn't stopped glaring at the walls since they left the classroom.

Not the water, not the ceiling, not the general wrongness of the hallway — the *walls* specifically, like he was waiting to catch them doing something. His grip on the crowbar hadn't loosened since they'd left the classroom.

"This whole building's rotting from the inside out, Entity's in the fuckin' plumbing," he muttered. "Watch your backs. Wouldn't be surprised if Her creepy-ass bug legs burst out of the floor next."

"Maybe don't tempt her, huh?" Orela muttered softly, sweeping her light nervously around the edges where the water met the walls.

"I'm just saying. She's right there. In the walls, in the pipes, in the floor. You can feel Her watching."

"I *know* She's watching. That's exactly why you should stop—"

"She's been fucking with us from the start. I'm sick of being watched and lied to by a *building*. It's like She thinks we can't tell." Jake gestured broadly at the hallway around them, water sloshing at his calves. "This is insulting, honestly. She's not even—"

"*Jake*."

"—being creative about it, She's just—"

Orela whipped around. "Can you *fucking not*?"

Jake blinked. "What?"

"I swear to every crawling god in this place, if you piss Her off more..."

A crack split the wall to his left.

Not fast. Not dramatic. Just a long slow fracture opening across the plaster from ceiling to baseboard, a deliberate and unhurried thing, trailing a thin seep of dark water from its edges like a signature. It bled down the wall and joined the water at their feet without ceremony.

The hallway went very quiet, the crack pulsing once then settling.

David turned away from the crack, his breath settling awkward and sharp in his chest. "Don't think She appreciates you shit-talking Her."

Orela's mouth was a tight line. "Maybe don't provoke the possessed demon school until *after* we find a way *out* of it?"

Jake gave a noncommittal grunt and turned back to the hall ahead, the flashlight finally landing on the warped shape of the front exit.

The front door looked like it had been underwater for years.

The wood had swollen into something barely recognizable — bloated and dark, the grain split in long weeping lines, the hinges reduced to rust suggestions that had long since fused to the frame. Mold trailing up the frame like veins. Metal and wood warped, paint bubbling in patches where water had soaked up from the base. Handles gleamed slickly. It looked less like a door now and more like something exhumed from the bottom of a lake.

Leon ran his hand along the edge of the frame, checking the gap — or rather, checking for where the gap should logically have been. The seal was complete.

"Still swollen shut. Could maybe force it, but..." He shook his head. "She's got it tight."

They crashed against it together, shoulders bruising, knuckles white around the warped handles. The frame groaned but didn't give. The impact landed with that same swallowed quality that everything in this building had, sound dying before it could properly echo, the force going somewhere that wasn't even remotely useful.

David bounced off the wood, water splashing against him as he staggered back, and something in his chest pulled wrong. He came away coughing — a hard, wet sound that had been building since the pipe hallway and had finally found its moment.

"You alright?" Orela asked.

"Fine," David rasped, waving her off as he fought back another wave. He rolled his shoulder, grit in his voice. "Just need a better angle."

The next crash echoed flatly through the hall, but the doors didn't move. Only the building seemed to groan louder, the heavily frosted glass of the windows flexing visibly in their frames. They tried again, straining, shoving, water slapping against their thighs with every surge, but the entryway held. Swollen. Bound. Denied.

Nothing.

Again.

Still nothing. The hinges groaned in complaint.

The crowbar idea was, theoretically, a good one.

In practice, the door presented a significant obstacle to the theory — specifically, the complete absence of any gap to wedge the crowbar into. The seal was total, wood swollen flush against frame, and getting any kind of purchase meant chipping at the surface first.

Wood flaked off in damp curls, but the door refused to budge. Leon jammed the tool into the edge, grunting with effort as he tried to lever the door free. David threw his weight in behind him, but the frame was a solid mass. No gap. No give. Leon braced with the crowbar again, gritting his teeth as he levered the swollen seam. David slammed his shoulder over and over, water splashing high with each hit. Orela tried to keep the light steady, her beam jerking with every shudder.

The water had found their knees.

David slammed his shoulder into the door again and had to pause against it, coughing, low and harsh, hand to his chest. Spitting out a mouthful of dark water, he resumed efforts again, trying to focus.

Orela hovered nearby, eyes darting between the wall leak and David's poorly masked pause. "This isn't working. It's not going to open," she said softly. "We need to try the back exit."

His hands tightened on the crowbar. They had been at this door for — he didn't know how long. Long enough that his shoulder had moved from insistent to genuinely angry. Long enough that the small pile of waterlogged wood chips floating away from their feet represented real effort, real time, and he was not interested in walking away from it.

"Just a little more," he said. "We're close."

Dwight's gaze darted down. The water was higher, having crept past his knees when he wasn't paying attention. His breath hitched. He shook his head, words tumbling out too fast. "We're wasting time. We have to move, try another exit. If we stay here..."

He reached toward Orela's flashlight, tugging at her sleeve as if to pull the beam with him. Panic edged his voice. "We *have* to go. Now."

Leon braced harder against the lever, jaw set. "It's just wood. It'll give. I've broken worse. We stop now, it'll open the second we walk away." His voice was calm, but iron. He wasn't quitting. Not yet.

"You guys are going to hurt yourselves like that! We need to try the other door!"

David slammed his shoulder in again, wincing at the vibration through bone. "He's right, we can't stop. One more hit. Just one more."

Orela looked between them — Dwight on one side with his hand on her arm, David and Leon on the other side still chipping at a door that had demonstrated absolutely no interest in cooperating — and felt the particular frustration of someone caught between two arguments that were both correct. They were going to hurt themselves if they kept going. They were also losing time standing here debating it. Both things were true and neither of them helped.

"David—"

"Not yet."

"Guys we have to GO—"

Her beam swung wildly, catching both of their faces in harsh slices of light. "**Enough!**" she barked, but it carried no decision, only the desperate need for one.

Jake had been quiet through all of this. He'd stepped back from the door a minute ago, watching the group with an expression that had shifted from impatient to something more considered.

"Hey." His voice cut through cleanly. "She wins if we keep doing this."

Heads snapped towards him.

"This." He gestured at the two of them at the door, at Dwight pulling at Orela, at the whole arrangement. "This is exactly what She wants. Us at each other's throats. It doesn't matter who's right. If we keep arguing, we're done."

David's hands had stilled on the crowbar. Leon had gone quiet.

"We move," Jake said. "Together. Now."

David and Leon stilled, leaning on the warped frame. Breathless, soaked, they staggered back, chests heaving. The tension in the air was palpable, both seeming to notice it properly for the first time.

Leon looked to David. Waited.

Another cough. A breath. David flexed lightly against the urge to argue. Jake was right, but that didn't make admitting defeat against a slab of rotten wood any easier. He gave the door an annoyed kick, water back-splashing against him in protest, then turned away from it.

"Yeah. Ok. Let's move."

Danny crouched low in a side room, the glow of his phone screen barely visible as he filmed their retreat, the survivors' shapes bobbing in and out of the flashlight's beam.

From this angle, they looked less like people and more like fish in a tank, drifting through a hallway-turned-aquarium. Every splash, every stagger, every breathless mutter... it was art. He whispered into his mask, chuckling.

"Swim faster, little minnows. Let's see if you find the glass."

Chapter 6 – Undertow

The hallway had become a canal.

Not dramatically — nothing in this building did anything dramatically anymore, preferring instead the slow patient version of every terrible thing. But somewhere between the front door and here the water had found the doorways and claimed them, rising until every opening along the hall was half-submerged, dark water lapping at the top of the frames with the quiet satisfaction of something that had been working toward this for a while.

Orela kept the flashlight forward and her pace steady. The surface shimmered with movement, but the flashlight's beam couldn't break through it. Too murky. Too reflective. Orela swept the light ahead, but it bounced back off the water like a mirror. The floor beneath it was invisible, with nothing to mark where the hallway ended and the hazards began. Every step was a guess. Every footfall could find solid tile or find nothing, and there was no way to know which until weight was committed.

"If you lose your footing in this," Orela warned, "We won't even see where you went down."

The water was too high now — licking mid-thigh — and the currents too deliberate. It tugged faintly, not downward, not outward. *Away*. From the walls. From the edges. Like the hallway itself was breathing inward.

Jake squinted at the far end. "It's pulling... do you feel that? It's not just rising. It's *pulling*..."

Dwight pushed past him, pale and jittering, every nerve screaming at him not to stand still anymore. "One at a time. We stick to the wall."

They moved slowly.

One of the basement stairwells appeared to their left — or rather, the top of its railing did, a few inches of metal standing above the waterline like a grave marker. Dwight glanced at it and

quickly looked away. It shouldn't have even been there in the first place, he noted mentally, not that it mattered. Nothing matched the layout he remembered anymore, and he would rather not think about it anyways.

Orela led them forward, flashlight tucked high against her collarbone, her feet making slow steady slides across tile she couldn't see. The beam caught glimpses of things beneath the surface — floating debris, a binder bloated with water, the shredded edge of a backpack. None of it sat still. The current nudged everything forward. The tiles were rough in places, near frictionless in others. She wished the light would break the surface better so at least she could tell what was in there.

Her toes grazed a sharp edge, foot sliding suddenly into nothing, the tile vanishing beneath her. She jerked to a stop, hand flailing briefly for balance. Leon caught her arm on reflex, tugging her back from the edge. The light swung wildly, and the rest of the group froze in place behind her.

Her flashlight beam skimmed across the water, catching the subtle fall where ripples slipped away into nothing. The hole into the basement was gone, swallowed entirely, leaving only a swirl of dark water that tugged on her legs expectantly.

She stepped back quickly, steadying herself. "It's open here," she whispered. "Holy shit, I almost missed it completely."

David flinched lightly at the ripples. "Should have seen that coming. Let me guess. Swim across?"

"We're not backtracking," Orela replied, voice firm. "I'm not going to risk wasting time checking classrooms to see if there's a roundabout way past. This is... unpleasant, but more direct. If we keep a hand on the wall and take it slow, it's not even that far across."

She didn't wait for argument. Slid down into the water, slow and deliberate, then pushed off from the edge. Her body cut clean through the surface, shoulders rising above the pull, and with a few practiced strokes, she crossed the open gap.

On the other side, she hauled herself up onto the shallow incline and swept the beam back across the black. From here she could keep the light on the others. Maybe make it a little less daunting. "Come on!"

Leon went first.

He lowered himself in without ceremony, one hand on the wall, keeping his eyes forward and slightly up the way he'd been doing since the hallway. Not looking at the water. Definitely not thinking about the particular quality of dark water, the way it closed over your shoulders like something deciding, the specific cold of a lake in summer that shouldn't have been cold but was—

He moved through it efficiently. Hand on the wall, feet finding the floor on the other side, up and out. Simple. Done.

David followed slower, sliding into the hole with a soft curse and kicking across it with mechanical rhythm. His limbs felt heavier in the water than they should. He didn't like it. Didn't like the silence, or the drag, or the way the space bent around them. But he made it.

Dwight whined once, a low pained sound in the depths of his chest, before following David.

The water lapped gently at his legs as the others waited on the far side. His hands trembled at his sides, stomach clenching uncomfortably, then settled into a low grumble. The last time he was in there had been absolute hell. Last time the dark had been complete and the water had been warm and patient and something had kept bumping his legs in the—

He got in.

This time, at least... there were eyes on him. David's hand found his arm on the other side before he'd even asked for it, hauling him up onto solid tile. His whole frame shook as he pulled free from the water.

Jake watched the others come up on the far side, dripping and breathing hard, and mentally measured the gap. The pressure in the wall shifted slightly and he side-eyed it for a moment, before tucking the crowbar into his belt and stepping forward.

The edge of the tile shifted under his foot.

Not dramatically — just a subtle wrongness under his leading foot, the tile angling wrong in a way that registered a half-second too late, then there was no floor. He didn't even get out a full warning. Just a single, startled "Shit—!" as the water closed over his head and the hole took him.

"Jake?!" Orela's light jerked toward the surface, but it only caught ripples. "Jake!"

Dwight moved on pure reflex, already leaning toward the gap before his brain had caught up with what was happening, and Orela's hand caught his arm and yanked him back hard enough to stagger him.

"Don't—"

He froze. Teetered. The edge was gone again. "He's not... he was *right there!*"

David was already stepping forward. "I'll get him—"

"No—!" The word came out of Dwight sharper than he'd intended, sharp enough to stop David mid-step. He didn't know where it came from. He just knew, with a certainty that sat in his chest like something physical, that David going back into that water was not something he could let happen.

Orela's jaw clenched. She shoved her flashlight into Leon's hands, voice low and steady even as her knuckles shook. "David's injured. You're the faster swimmer out of us. You've got the best chance. Find him."

Leon stared at the light for half a second too long, then down at the black water yawning in front of him. His jaw tightened.

The universe, he thought, had a very specific and deeply personal sense of humor. Of course it would be him. It was just his luck. He'd prevented the end of the world more times than he could count on one hand and apparently the lesson the cosmos had taken from that was *this guy can handle anything, let's keep testing it*. The lake water surfaced briefly in the back of his mind and he put it down. He obviously wasn't going to leave Jake behind.

He handed Orela his vest, checked his grip on the flashlight, took a few steadying breaths, dove clean, and vanished beneath the surface.

The darkness swallowed the beam almost immediately. The others watched the light sink below the surface and disappear, and then there was nothing. Just the water lapping softly at the edge of the hole and five people minus one standing very still in the dark.

Nobody moved. The floor had already demonstrated what it thought about people who moved.

Dwight counted his own heartbeats and tried not to think about the last time he'd been waiting for someone to come back up through a hole in the floor. That time everything had happened fast, the water rising, the clock obvious and urgent. This was slower. The waiting stretched and the dark pressed in and slow, it turned out, was its own particular kind of terrible.

David cursed gently to himself, trying to calm the reflexive itch in his lungs. Dwight's outcry rang sharp in his mind, and for a moment he was back in the basement; lost, panicked, flailing at everything rhythm touched him. Dwight had nearly lost him down there, and he just tried to go right back in without even thinking. His own bull-headed reflexes were causing pain on others. They were already scared enough. He needed to get them out before it got worse.

Orela stared at the spot where she had last seen the light and tried not to second guess herself. Leon had gone in reluctantly — she'd seen it, the particular quality of his hesitation, something underneath the pragmatism that he wasn't going to name and she wasn't going to ask about. He seemed to be struggling with something beyond just the darkness and the rising threat. The man clearly had baggage; Orela had seen that look before. She didn't know him that well, he wasn't really one to open up about his time before the Fog, but if something down there triggered an episode in him, it could be extremely bad for everyone.

Beyond it all, though, was a single shared understanding.

If Leon didn't come back, they were down two people and their only light source.

The water lapped softly at the edge of the hole.

The basement was unrecognizable.

Leon's hands found the pipe just beneath the surface and clung to it hard. He didn't kick — didn't fight the current — just pulled himself forward along the ceiling, trying to save energy while he searched.

The basement was wrong. The entire area was foreign — somehow both too small and too large at once — swollen and warped out of shape in unnatural, unrecognizable configurations. But the pressure folded in all the same. Columns were shattered. Furniture drifted like corpses. Concrete sheared open. Rebar jutted like bones from a ribcage halfway through collapse.

The flashlight cut maybe four feet in any direction before the water swallowed it. Everything beyond that was shadow.

The shadows kept looking like people.

He grabbed at one — fabric, he'd thought, or an arm, or something — and his knuckles came back scraped against broken concrete. He grabbed at another and found a shelf corner. He stopped grabbing at shadows.

Something had settled down here. That was the feeling of it — not abandoned, not empty, but *claimed*. The debris wasn't random the way one might expect from a flood. It had the quality of accumulation, of things drawn in and kept. The current moved through it in slow deliberate patterns that didn't quite match the angles of the space.

He pushed deeper, ears roaring, light darting in frantic sweeps. *Come on, Jake. Where are you?*

The dark lake water surfaced briefly at the back of his mind. The pressure of something large moving beneath—

He pulled himself forward along the next pipe. Found the next one. Kept moving.

He hauled forward one grip at a time, flashlight clamped in his fist, beam darting through the water like a scalpel.

The current tugged hard now. Not enough to sweep him outright, but enough to throw him off course with every pull. He gritted his teeth, adjusted, and kept going.

Shapes moved below him. Pale smears and dark shadows. He kicked once to steer around a floating chair and nearly slammed his shin into what might've been a filing cabinet. The pain lanced through his leg, and he winced tight against it, familiar panic sparking in the back of his throat.

He forced it down.

Focus.

Focus.

He swept the light again.

Leon saw the movement first — a disturbance in the water below him, too deliberate for current, too rhythmic for debris — and angled the flashlight down.

The Entity's claws had come through the floor.

Not violently. Not dramatically. They'd simply *grown* there, pushing up through the concrete like roots push through a sidewalk — patient and inevitable and completely indifferent to what the floor thought about it. Three of them visible in the beam, dark and articulated and wrong in the specific way that things with too many joints were wrong. One of them had Jake.

Not aggressively. That was the thing that made it worse. The claw had hooked itself into the fabric of his pant leg and was *tugging* — gently, almost playfully, letting him rise up a bit before smoothly sinking him again. Jake flailed violently against it, twisting, eyes wide, limbs kicking at what he had assumed was floating trash. He had been fighting something he couldn't see, and now that the light had found him, the shift in him was immediate and total.

The stressed tension of *I'm caught on something* became the flailing panic of *I can see what has me* and those were completely different animals.

Leon kicked sharp off the wall.

He dropped fast, grabbing Jake around the torso, one arm clamping across his ribs as the other jammed the flashlight into the crook of his elbow as Jake grabbed at his arm, trying to climb him to freedom. He kicked down hard past Jake at the claw, connecting sharply along the edge. It flexed but held. Leon kicked again, striking where the claw curled. Jake *screamed* something underwater — more air bubbles than sound — as the tension tightened. The claw flinched sharply, ripping into the pant leg and almost tugging Jake out of Leon's arms. He aimed another kick down, and another.

The tip of the claw split, a shard slicing through Jake's leg as the rest recoiled. The cut bloomed scarlet, the water drinking it fast. Jake thrashed, twisting hard against Leon's hold.

The other claws lashed out immediately, reaching, trying to reclaim their prize.

No time.

Leon turned, twisting upward, dragging Jake through the chaos and out of range of the Entity's claws. Jake was half-kicking, half-flailing, trying to help, but his strength was gone and his leg wouldn't move right. Leon could feel it — the dead weight setting in. His own limbs burned. His lungs were screaming.

But the light still worked, and that beam led them cleanly up, sputtering bright against the ceiling until, at last, it found the edges of the gap. He never bothered looking back to see if the claws were following. In his mind, they were already reaching out for him from the dark.

His fingers found the pipe again and *dragged*.

He didn't look back.

The hole was where he'd left it.

They surfaced in a violent crash — Jake bursting first in a flailing panic, Leon a heartbeat behind, his shoulder cracking sharp against the tile. Chests heaving. Coughing. Gagging up water between breaths that tasted like blood and mold with enough force that if they had the breath for it, they would have surfaced screaming.

The others were already there — Orela's hands finding Jake's arm, Dwight surging forward after a single paralyzed breath of relief. Leon collapsed half into the hallway, half into the water, David catching him by the back of the shirt and pulling him fully onto the tile before he slid back in.

"Hey — hey, I got you," he muttered, bracing his weight and firmly thumping his back as Leon choked on another mouthful of water and shuddered violently. He held him steady until the spasms passed. "You're one lucky bastard, you know that?"

Jake coughed so hard he nearly vomited. He sagged into Orela's hold as he caught his breath. *"She moved the fucking floor."*

His voice had a quality to it that hadn't been there before — stripped of the arrogant edge it had earlier, raw underneath. "I felt it shift. I *knew* She was in the building and I stepped on it anyway and She just—" He stopped. "It was just playing with me. It had me and it was just—"

"It's ok. You're out," Orela ran her hand over his leg, assessing the cut with quick professional focus. "It's not deep, Messy, but not deep. You'll be fine, so long as whatever's in this water doesn't give you a random infection."

Jake looked at the hole. At the water lapping at its edge with that same patient quality it had had all night.

"I've had worse," Jake muttered, wiping his face and wincing as Orela tied his bandana around the cut, slowing the bleed to a more reasonable level.

Dwight stared at them both, still breathing too fast as anxiety clamped around him.

David kept a hand on Leon's shoulder, not to steady him anymore — but to ground himself.

The hallway fell into a quiet tension. Just the sound of their breath. The creak of the building. And the water lapping, steady as ever, just behind them.

From the classroom doorway, Danny's phone caught everything; the thrash of the beam below water, the long, terrifying silence, the sudden eruption of two soaked survivors clawing back to life. He zoomed in, framed it perfectly.

On the RC feed from his submersible, the lens had tracked them the whole way, Jake's bubbles scattering, Leon's frantic dive, the scramble back to air. A perfect double angle.

Danny chuckled low into his mask, whispering like a delighted commentator. "And there it is, back from the brink. Lucky boys. She's playing with you now! Better get a move on."

He zoomed in. Framed it. Waited.

Ch 7 – Floodgate

The back door was worse than the front.

That shouldn't have been possible. The front door had been a wall wearing a door's memory — swollen past function, the frame warped into something that had forgotten what gaps were for. But this one had gone further, past bloated and into something that looked almost geological. The wood had darkened to near-black, grain split in long weeping lines, the surface slick and soft in places where it had absorbed so much water it had stopped being wood in any

meaningful sense. The metal was gone entirely — hinges, handle, strike plate, all of it reduced to rust-colored suggestions fused permanently to the frame. Even the seam where door met wall had disappeared, the entire frame curled outward like it had been soaking for decades.

David hit it anyway. Shoulder first, weight behind it, the impact landing with that same swallowed quality that everything in this building produced — force going in, nothing coming back. Leon followed with a length of shelving, the metal edge finding no purchase on a surface too soft to catch and too solid to dent. Jake worked the bottom with his boot, then his knee, then his boot again. The water climbed past their hips and shifted with every impact, sloshing back against their legs like a rebuttal.

The crowbar was gone. Somewhere in the hallway, or the particular pocket of dark water that had taken Jake and had likely kept what fell out of his hands as a consolation prize. They were down to bodies and debris, and the door received both with the same patient indifference.

Dwight had his back to the wall, arms wrapped tight against himself. His eyes kept flicking down to the water creeping up his legs, the anxiety sucking at his ribs. The flow had quieted — not stagnant, but sluggish — dragged thin across the endless sprawl of the building. It left behind a slick murk clinging to corners, swallowing dropped tools and broken tile alike.

It crawled up the grout — slow but certain. He watched it tick past a screw left embedded in the tile. Then past a crack in the plaster. His lips moved again, quieter, a whisper under his breath. "Five... there's five of us. There shouldn't be five."

The others didn't notice, too caught in the rhythm of smashing and straining. Their grunts filled the hallway. The sharp clang of a metal desk leg on rotted wood. The curse of another wasted swing. But Dwight's eyes were wide, haunted, thoughts spiraling.

"Four survivors," he whispered. "Two gates. Four skills. Two exits. Always balance. Always ritual. The Entity loved symmetry. So why..."

He trailed off.

Five people.

His lips moved silently, mumbling, counting.

Five.

It's never five. Why?

The question chased its own tail. He pressed his palm flat against the wall behind him, feeling the damp of it, and tried to find the shape of what was nagging at him.

The math was ruthless but it was clean. It accounted for everyone.

Five didn't account for everyone.

His eyes moved across the group without meaning to, cataloguing. David. Leon. Jake. Orela.

Is one of us not meant to—

He didn't finish the thought. Pressed it back down, hard, and fixed his gaze on the door like that would help.

Down the hall, Danny had found himself a perch.

The cabinet had toppled at some point during the building's ongoing renovation of itself, landing at an angle against the wall that made it serviceable enough — one knee pulled up beneath his arm, the other foot dangling just above the water.

He was lip reading again. It wasn't difficult — survivors in distress had a limited vocabulary, and the body language filled in most of the gaps the distance created. David was swearing at the door. Leon was suggesting something David didn't want to hear. Jake was agreeing with Leon, which David also didn't want to hear. Standard.

He stifled a yawn behind his mask.

Since the basement rescue, the group had consolidated into something almost boring — five people moving with grim shared purpose toward a goal that wasn't going to cooperate with them, working a door that had made its position clear approximately twenty minutes ago. Competent enough, under the circumstances. Dull to watch. The basement had been genuinely entertaining. The pipe hallway had been a masterpiece. This was just attrition dressed up as effort, and he'd filmed enough of it already.

"Come on, guys. Give me something dramatic."

He shifted his weight on the cabinet and waited for something to happen.

The lens swept across the group and snagged on Dwight.

He'd been tracking the door crew on autopilot, but Dwight pulled his focus back. Something was just slightly wrong about the quality of his stillness. He wasn't watching the door. Wasn't watching the water. Just standing against the wall with his palm flat to the plaster and his lips moving in something too small and too steady to be talking to anyone. His eyes kept moving across the group in that particular way — not checking on them, not looking for reassurance. He almost seemed to be counting.

“Ooo what have we here? Do I sense a crack in the resolve?”

Danny watched him through the green-tinted lens and felt something adjacent to pity.

The man had been dunked twice, dragged through a flooded maze in the dark, and was now standing hip-deep in whatever this building was turning into, quietly coming apart over what looked like an arithmetic problem. Bless. The twitchy ones always found something to fixate on when the adrenaline ran out of places to go. Numbers, patterns, routines — anything the brain could chew on to avoid sitting with the actual situation. He'd seen it before. He'd filmed it before.

He zoomed in, tracking the shape of his muttering as he whispered, “Five... why are there five people? It's never an odd number!”

Danny chuckled softly, rolling his eyes and rapping the butt of his knife softly against the cabinet's side in idle rhythm while zooming back in on the futile struggle at the door.

“Guy is losing it. Already spiraling in on himself and obsessing over nothing. He's not even helping them anymore. Oh nooo an odd number in the school! Honestly, if he's so upset about the numbers, he can chill. I'm here too. Nice even six. Better?”

The sarcasm landed hollow. He chuckled anyway.

The amusement faded a little faster than it should have.

Danny tapped the hilt of his knife against the cabinet edge, a slow idle rhythm, and watched Dwight count his people for what was probably the fourth time. The motion settled him, usually — something to do with his hands while his brain ran wherever it wanted to go. It wasn't settling him now. There was something sitting at the back of his thoughts that hadn't been there thirty seconds ago, shapeless and faintly irritating.

He turned his attention back to the door crew and let it sit.

Clearly the man was cracking. Two trips through a flooded maze in pitch dark would do that to anyone, and Dwight had never been what you'd call a stable baseline to begin with. Twitchy. Overthought everything. The kind of person who needed the rules to make sense or the whole framework started wobbling. Made him a decent leader in a normal trial — pattern recognition, steady under pressure, knew the rhythm of things — and made him exactly this in a trial that had stopped following rules an hour ago. The odd number was probably just a loose thread his brain had found and couldn't stop pulling.

The knife hilt rapped softly. Once. Twice.

Although...

She did love her rituals. That was just true. The whole apparatus of a trial ran on repetition, on symmetry, on the same beats landing in the same order often enough that it bordered on obsession. He'd run more trials than he could count and the numbers never varied, not once, not even when everything else about a domain went sideways. The structure held because the structure was the point.

This whole night had been a weird flex on Her part. The flooding alone was unusual — theatrical, expensive, not Her typical economy of effort. She fed on fear, not spectacle. Spectacle was a means to an end and usually a fairly efficient one, not a whole elaborate aquarium with rising water and geometry that kept rewriting itself. That was a lot of energy for one trial. More than made sense.

And She'd done it with five people.

Danny stopped tapping.

He looked at the group again — not through the lens, just looked, the phone dropping slightly in his hand. Five people at a door that wasn't opening, in a building that was doing something sustained and deliberate and costly, and She had set all of it in motion with a number that didn't fit Her own ritual logic.

Fuck. He's starting to sound like them. Maybe the mold in the air was getting to him too.

This place had been wet for hours and he'd been breathing whatever was in the air the same as everyone else, and it was apparently doing something to his higher functions. He exhaled through his nose and directed his attention firmly back to the door.

The thought sat there anyway, refusing to fade off.

He shifted on the cabinet, crossing his legs and rolling his shoulders against the pull of the leather. The shoulder pads creaked quietly in protest, the leather of the robe sticking slightly with each motion, heavier than usual. Weighted. Trapping warmth instead of wicking it off like normal. He winced. The outfit was fantastic for blending in with the shadows, both flexible and breathable, but it was heavy at the best of times.

Right now, it sat heavier on him than he remembered. Every seam had absorbed something. The underlayer clung. He'd been carrying the extra weight long enough that he'd stopped registering it consciously, which probably explained why his back had opinions that it was only now getting around to voicing. He'd peel it off later, hang it up, let it dry properly. Later problem.

He glanced down at his phone, adjusting his grip, and the faint glow of the screen caught the air around his hands.

No fog.

Not the building's water-thick atmosphere — that was everywhere, unavoidable, a permanent feature of the evening. His fog. The particular dark that clung to him when he didn't want to be seen, that softened his edges and swallowed his silhouette and had been as automatic as breathing since the first trial. It was just there. It was always just there.

He turned his hand over slowly in the phone's light.

Nothing. Just his hand. Just air. No shimmer of stealth, no ripple of distortion, no indication he had been cloaked at all, really.

And come to think of it... he had no idea how long he'd even been fully visible for. Had he been uncloaked this whole time?

He looked up at the group — really looked, the lens forgotten — and did the math with the particular speed of someone who had spent years reading rooms for a living. Orela's flashlight had swept this hallway. Multiple times. He'd been sitting on a toppled cabinet in the open, phone out, knife visible, not eight meters away, and not one of them had so much as flinched in his direction.

“...Huh.”

How did the others not feel him there?

Was his terror radius even active?

He reached inward for the low constant pulse of it, the thing that kept prey at the right edge of awareness. The thing that had always been there.

The silence where it should have been was very loud.

Across the hallway, Dwight was still against his wall. Still counting. Still wearing that expression — hollowed out, fraying at the edges, the look of someone standing at the threshold of understanding something they didn't want to understand.

Danny looked at him for a long moment.

No stealth.

No presence.

No terror radius.

“...Wait.”

The school flinched inward.

All at once, simultaneously, every seam in the building giving up the pretense at the same moment — as if it had been holding its breath since the trial started and had finally, finally found its cue.

The pipes went first. Not a chain reaction building from a source — all of them, the entire network detonating in the same instant with a shriek of pressure that compressed the air and hit the ears like a physical thing. Locker doors flew open along the hallway's length, torn off their hinges by the force of what came through them, water exploding outward in solid jets that crossed the corridor and hit the opposite wall hard enough to strip paint. Some doors didn't open at all — they shattered, the metal folding outward in jagged petals as the water behind them stopped asking permission. Ceiling tiles buckled and dropped, each one releasing its own small waterfall that joined the roar before it hit the floor, the sound building on itself until it stopped being individual sources and became a single deafening presence that swallowed everything inside it.

The surge scattered the survivors across the flooded foyer, drowning out their yells beneath its violent crescendo, consuming the survivor's panicked screaming shouts, and dousing them in spray from all sides.

Orela's flashlight became a liability.

The beam swung wild as the first jets hit — catching nothing useful, just strobing across walls and water and the shapes of people staggering, the light more disorienting than the dark had been. She swept it hard left, trying to find something solid to orient by, and a pressure wave caught her from the right and took her feet. The beam lurched toward the ceiling. Her shoulder hit something — a locker, a wall, she couldn't tell — before Leon's arm came across her chest and pulled, hauling her back against him and turning his body into a windbreak between her and the spray. She got a hand against the wall. Held.

Across the foyer, Jake moved on reflex.

He'd seen Dwight's legs go the instant the first wave hit — no purchase, no warning, just a man with too much height and not enough weight suddenly at the mercy of a current that had been waiting for exactly this. Jake was already moving when Dwight started to go down, closing the distance in two lurching strides, catching him by the arm and driving him hard into the nearest corner. He planted himself between Dwight and the worst of it, braced wide, and held.

At the door, David had nowhere to go.

The door was at his back — immovable, indifferent, the same door that had absorbed everything they'd thrown at it all night — and the water was at his front, coming in from three directions at once. He got his arm up, elbow leading, and turned his face into his shoulder as a jet caught him across the chest and drove the breath out of him. The force of it ground him back against the wood. He pushed into it, found his footing, lost it, found it again. Another wave hit, lower, and the cold of it surged up his torso. He coughed hard into his own arm and kept his feet.

Down the hall, Danny was torn loose.

No warning, no build — one moment he was sitting upright processing the worst realization of his evening, and the next the perch he'd been lounging on became a slipway as a high-pressure

spray nailed him across the ribs and the cabinet was gone and the wall was somewhere his body was traveling toward at significant speed. The impact drove the air out of him completely, shoulder and cheek connecting with the lockers hard enough to see white, and he had approximately half a second to register that he'd lost the phone before the current got his legs and the floor stopped being a concept he had access to.

The knife went somewhere. He didn't see it go.

He got a hand on the lockers — fingertips, nothing to grip, the surface slick and featureless — and the current pulled his legs out from under him with casual thoroughness and dragged him out into the hallway proper, away from the walls, into the open water where the pressure waves from half a dozen competing jets were doing something violent to the current. He twisted, trying to get upright, and a wave caught him from behind and flipped him. He twisted again. Got his head above water for a breath, got it driven back under by the next impact.

The robes were catastrophic.

The long leather danced with the current, becoming a heavy fishing net — wrapping, tangling, adding weight in all the wrong places and drag in every direction. He fought toward the nearest wall, arms pulling hard, and made it approximately a meter before a pressure wave shoved him back into the swirl. Pressure waves knocked him senseless — too strong to fight, too chaotic to predict. His arms flailed wide for something, *anything* solid, but every grip slipped. He grabbed for a locker door hanging open and got it wrenched out of his hand before his fingers could close. The current spun him, patient and enormous, and pulled him further from anything solid.

The mask flooded.

It filled all at once, the cowl acting as a funnel, and suddenly there was no air inside it, just cold water pressing against his face from every angle with nowhere for it to go. He choked on the first instinctive inhale, got water instead of air, and his hands found the mask purely on survival reflex — no decision, no thought, just the absolute biological certainty that this had to come off *right now*.

The buckle fought him. His fingers weren't working right, too cold and too clumsy, and for three seconds that lasted considerably longer than three seconds he was just a man underwater in the dark pulling at his own face. Then the clasp gave, the cowl peeled free, and he shoved it away from him.

The current took it immediately. No ceremony. Just gone, swallowed into the dark like it had never been there.

The water hit his face without it.

He'd forgotten what that felt like — the full exposure of it, nothing between him and whatever was coming. He broke the surface gagging, hair plastered flat, water streaming into his eyes. Jets slammed him from both sides, slapping him into debris and wrenching him away again. A floating chair cracked off his shoulder. The tiled floor vanished beneath him; the ceiling overhead lost to the chaos. His robe wrapped around his legs, tangling, dragging. A jet caught him directly across the jaw and snapped his head sideways. He got his arm up too late, took another wave to the ear, and the world tilted hard to the left in a way that had nothing to do with the current. He kicked toward where the wall should have been and connected with debris instead — something solid and angular that spun away on impact and told him nothing about where he was. Another jet found his shoulder and drove him under. He came back up coughing, spitting, the cold of it biting into his face with nothing left to stop it.

He couldn't get stable. Every time he found a direction, the competing currents disagreed about it.

His hands found the wall.

The current tore them free.

He found it again — different wall, different section, his palm flat against tile for one lurching second — and then a pressure wave hit from the left and he was spinning again, the robes a dead weight spiraling with him, and the wall was somewhere behind him in the dark.

He stopped trying to find it, focusing instead on just trying to stay above the surface.

The hallway had no geography anymore. No walls he could hold, no floor he could trust, no direction that stayed consistent long enough to be useful. Just water in every direction and the occasional brutal introduction to something solid that told him nothing except that it was there and then wasn't.

He'd been in bad trials. He'd been the thing making them bad, usually — the pressure, the presence, the particular weight of knowing someone was coming and not knowing when. He understood fear from the outside in. Had studied it, cultivated it, learned its specific frequencies and how to play them.

He had not, in a very long time, been afraid.

The current rolled him and he lost the surface and came up gasping with no idea which way he'd come from, and underneath the kicking and the cold and the roar of water that had

swallowed every other sound in the building, something landed that he didn't have the breath or the composure to look at directly.

She left me.

Not a surprise — he'd understood that the moment he'd checked for his terror radius and found nothing. He'd done the math. He knew what it meant. But understanding a thing and being inside it were different animals entirely, and he was inside it now, in the dark, in the water, stripped of the mask and the knife and the phone and every other layer he'd built up between himself and exactly this. No protection. No guidance. No particular value to anything that might be watching.

Just a man in a flooding hallway.

Just more meat in the tank.

The current pulled him under again, and this time when he fought back to the surface it was pure reflex, nothing behind it but the dumb animal insistence on one more breath.

That was all he had left.

Ch 8 – Flotsam

The hallway screamed with water and metal.

Orela's flashlight arced wildly through the chaos, cutting sharp glints into the shattered mess around them — a locker door hanging open, water sheeting off the ceiling in solid curtains, the shape of Jake braced in a corner with Dwight pinned against him, David trying to hide his face against his arms in a futile effort to keep the back spray out of his sinuses. And still the current surged — not enough to sweep them fully, but more than enough to throw them off balance. She swept right. Debris. She swept left. Wall. She swept further and the beam caught something that wasn't wall and wasn't debris — a shape, flailing, bouncing off the lockers like a ragdoll.

She didn't place him immediately — the distance was wrong, the shape was wrong without the robes reading the way they usually did — and then Leon's hand closed on her arm and she felt him go rigid beside her, and that was enough. She followed his eyes, looked again, and this time the shape resolved.

She grabbed Leon's sleeve and pointed, hard, then turned and started waving at the others.

Dwight saw where they were looking and moved without thinking. The water sloshed hard as he pushed off the wall, slamming forward through the current.

One moment he was against the wall with Jake's arm across him, the next he was pushing forward through the water, shouldering past without explanation, eyes fixed on the shape tumbling down the hallway. He didn't think about the current. Didn't think about the water level or the pressure waves or the fact that his legs had barely been reliable for the last hour. He just moved — some part of him that operated below the threshold of good judgment simply seeing someone struggling and moving in to help.

David's hand caught his arm and yanked him back hard enough to stagger him, pulling him close enough to make himself heard over the roar.

"DON'T! What the hell do you think you're doing?!"

"We can't just leave him!" He pulled against David's grip, a fierce determination in his eyes.

"We sure as fuck CAN!"

"David—"

"Did you forget what he IS?"

Jake grimaced behind them, catching the light as it rocked in Orela's hand. She didn't join the argument — didn't seem to hear it at all, really — as she pressed the flashlight into Jake's hands, pulling his arm up to angle the beam down the hall with the clear intent for him to keep her way lit up.

She motioned to Leon to follow her, before bracing her arms and beginning to push through the deepening flood. She had been unable to feel helpful at all this entire time, with David clearly needing help but rejecting it, and the others barely standing still long enough for her to even assess them. But here was something she COULD accomplish. Killer or not, she wasn't going to just let someone drown not even 60 feet away. Not if she could do something about it.

Behind her, Dwight met David's eyes.

It wasn't a long standoff. Dwight didn't have David's build or his stubbornness, and they both knew it — a straight contest of wills between them had a predictable outcome. But Dwight held the look, steady, and something in it must have landed, because David's grip on his arm loosened by degrees.

Dwight wrenched his arm back, and David finally let go.

He watched Dwight half swim, half sprint off after Orela, then turned back to resume battering at the door. Someone had to keep working on the exit. Someone had to be practical about this. He put his shoulder into it again and tried not to think about what was happening down the hall. He needed to get the others out before their own altruism got them all killed.

Leon made it two steps.

His breath hitched as he watched Orela go. His feet planted, shoulders tense, the flicker of the beam reflecting off her soaked shirt as she moved into the darkness, Dwight hot on her heels. Leon moved to follow the rescue team but froze in place. His brain screamed at him to move — **go** — but the water was so high now, pulling at his legs and stomach in unnatural swirls of current. The surface was so intensely dark. The faint memory of a black claw coiled towards him, seizing his spine. He tried to step forward and nothing moved. Every inch of him had locked up, heart hammering, legs unwilling.

Jake's touch on his arm shattered the moment and he startled, eyes wild and chest heaving, as the flashlight was pushed into his hands.

"I got you, man. Just keep us lit as best you can, ok? I'll make sure they come back."

Leon swallowed once, eyes flicking to Orela's shrinking silhouette, then back to Jake. An embarrassed nod of understanding passed between them and Jake turned to paddle after the others, leaving Leon to curse at his own freeze up. The moment had passed but the sting of it sat deep in him as he trained the light down the hall onto his friends.

Orela's boots skidded once, then bit. She leaned hard into the current, arms braced forward. Danny breached the surface in a sputtering mess of limbs and panic just as she reached him, and she snagged him — fingers locking in the collar of his sodden robes.

The drag was considerable. He was soaked through. Every inch of that heavy leather robe, canvas wraps, thick gloves — a walking anchor now clinging to her arm, trying to climb straight

up her. His weight unbalanced her, and Orela went sideways and down before she'd fully registered what was happening. Her shoulder hit the wall and then his hands were on her shoulders and he was pulling down — not intentionally, just pure animal logic and a drive to go *UP* — and for one lurching second, they were both going under.

Her shoulder slid across the wall. She got her back against it and held, both hands locked in his collar, teeth gritted, the pull of him dragging at her arms with a steady insistence that threatened to twist her loose from her precarious stability.

Dwight reached her first, plastering himself against the wall and grabbing her arm with both hands, anchoring. Jake was a half second behind, getting a hand into the back of Danny's collar alongside hers, and the three of them formed a human chain against the wall — Dwight braced and pulling, Orela holding, Jake hauling — working Danny hand over hand out of the current's reach and back toward solid footing. Danny thrashed against the sucking current, panic-born, nearly tearing free from the grip as the three dragged him back towards the wall away from the jets of chaos with everything they had.

They got him against the wall and held him there while he fell apart.

Danny collapsed against the wall, nearly sliding right back into the water were it not for the boys at each arm holding him upright, coughing up water in long, wracking heaves, one hand braced against Dwight's shoulder without appearing to register it was there. Blood tracked down from somewhere above his hairline, thinned to pink by the water. His lip was split. The whole of him slumped like dead weight, eyes barely tracking.

Orela's hands went straight to the soaked folds of his robe. The fabric clung to his frame, leather straps pinning it against him, water pouring off it in sheets.

"Off," she snapped, already tugging at the collar. "You may as well have worn a damned anchor. What kind of idiot wears twenty layers in a goddamn aquarium?!"

She got her fingers under the first buckle, wrenching it apart with a practiced efficiency. The leather resisted — swollen, stiff, the hardware fused with water and pressure — and she worked it loose by force of will, peeling the first layer back and shoving it into the current without ceremony. It went immediately, swallowed by the dark water like it was glad to be rid of the job. The next layer followed. Then the one beneath that, canvas and lining and the waterlogged padding that had been adding weight to weight for the better part of an hour.

The robe peeled over his head in sodden layers, straps slapping wetly against her arm as she tossed them aside.

"You're not dying on me because you're too stupid to change clothes," she growled, medic's patience long gone.

Danny wheezed, eyes half-shut, but didn't argue. No jokes. No bravado. Just silence, shivering with spent adrenaline under their hands as nearly 30 pounds of cloth came free and hit the water with a heavy slap, slowly vanishing into the darkness below. The last of the sodden layers vanished into the current behind them. Gone.

Beneath all the armor and theatre, there was just... a guy. Drenched. Pale. Shaking. Human

That was the thing that struck Dwight, standing there in the churning dark with his hand still on Danny's arm — the sheer unremarkability of what was underneath. Jeans. A t-shirt, soaked through and clinging. Dark hair plastered flat. A face that, without the mask and the cowl and the whole assembled architecture of the thing, was just a face. Younger than expected, maybe. Harder to read without the framing.

He was still shaking. Trying not to show it, or maybe past the point of being able to manage that particular performance. Either way, he vibrated lightly in place.

Jake appeared at Dwight's shoulder, angling his voice close to be heard. "We should get back to the foyer. Hall's turning everything into a whirlpool — more room to move back there. Less chance of someone else going for a swim."

Dwight nodded. Looked at Danny, who was looking at nothing in particular, water dripping from his chin in a thin steady stream.

"Come on," Dwight said. Not a question.

Danny came. There wasn't anywhere else to go, and they all understood that without it needing to be said. The boys each took a side and helped the soaked killer navigate back along the thin beam of light, Orela's hand at his back, as they quietly folded him into the group. Just another fish in the Entity's fucked-up waterpark.

Back in the foyer the water moved differently — the slightly wider space diffused the worst of the pressure waves into something that only shoved rather than spun. Jake peeled off toward the door without being asked, grabbed a chunk of metal debris, and started jamming it between the warped edge of the door and its swollen frame. David grunted in frustrated

rhythm at his side, muscles straining as he tried again to wrench the damn thing loose. Nothing gave. The door might as well have been part of the wall itself now.

Orela commandeered the flashlight from Leon with a look and turned it on Danny, running a quick efficient assessment — the cut above his hairline, the bruising already darkening along his jaw and shoulder, the way he was holding his ribs on the left side with careful stillness. His pupils tracked sluggishly, breath tight and wet. He barely seemed aware, as if he had retreated into himself and away from the chaos around them. She could barely blame him.

Leon moved to help with the door again, clearly shaken. As he passed Jake, something passed between them — a glance, brief and level, and a small nod from Jake that said nothing and everything. Leon's chin dipped once in return. It was done in a second, quiet enough that it might not have happened at all.

Dwight caught it. Filed it away without comment. Now was not the time.

He looked back at Danny instead — at the cut on his temple and the set of his jaw and the particular vacancy behind his eyes that Dwight recognised from the inside — and felt the last piece slide into place with the specific, terrible quality of something that had been true for a while before he'd been ready to see it.

Six.

There had always been six. Danny hadn't wandered into their trial by accident; he had been there when Dwight and David entered the building. He was the sixth, the numbers settled and even like every ritual trial that came before, and the Entity had known that when She set the whole thing in motion.

Which meant the count had been right all along.

Which meant nobody was marked.

Which meant all of them were.

Dwight kept his face still and his mouth shut and looked at the waterline climbing the wall behind Danny, and did not say any of this out loud.

They pushed again. Slammed. Wedged. Cursed.

Nothing.

The roar was constant; water hammering from ceilings, gushing from ruptured lockers, sluicing down halls, but within the shift was happening quietly — beneath the roar of water and the crash of falling debris, something subtler was bleeding through.

Fatigue.

Disbelief.

The door work continued — Jake and David and Leon cycling through angles, trying leverage points the wood had already refused, finding new sections of frame to test and receiving the same answer from all of them. The sounds of it were the same sounds they'd been making for the better part of an hour. Impact. Resistance. Reset. Impact again.

But something had gone out of it.

Not the effort, exactly. The belief behind the effort. The quality of each strike shifted by degrees, the force behind it becoming less about breaking through and more about having something to do with hands that didn't know what else to try. The pauses between attempts got longer. The resets got slower. Nobody called it. Nobody said the word. They just gradually stopped pretending the door was going to open and kept working it anyway because stopping meant standing in chest-high water with nowhere to look that wasn't bad.

David was the last to still.

He'd been running on something past exhaustion for a while now — some reserve below the reserve, stubbornness metabolised into fuel — and it had finally spent itself against a door that hadn't moved a millimetre in response to any of it. His shoulder sagged against the door, and he wiped the water from his face with the back of his wrist. His eyes darted around the hallway around them, the dark water and the debris and the five — six — people standing in it, as if the answer might be somewhere in the room if he just kept his eyes moving long enough to find it.

Leon's hand moved over the doorframe one more time, slow and deliberate, fingers reading the grain like there was something in the wood he hadn't found yet. His eyes tracked the foyer in quick passes — ceiling, walls, the hallway, back to the door — as if the trick to opening it had just been missed somehow. His jaw was tight, eyes unfocused, every inch of his mind trying to slap down the question of just how much time they had.

Jake had backed into the corner where the foyer met the hall, shoulders against the junction of two walls, arms wrapped around himself. His hands moved over his own forearms in short restless passes. His eyes were down, following the shadows against the walls as if tracking the waterline creeping higher.

Danny had listed sideways until his shoulder found Orela's, the effort of staying upright more exhausting than it was worth in the moment. She'd let him, which said something about the state of things. He was looking at the group with an expression that had shed all of its earlier distance — watching the survivors like he was one of them now — and realizing just how *little* that meant down here. One hand twitched idly at his side, reaching for the phantom of a knife that was long lost.

Orela kept her eyes on the door.

Nobody had to say it.

They could all feel it pressing in around them.

The basement had filled from the ground up, patient and complete, until it had nowhere left to go but through the ceiling. The main doors had taken everything they had and given nothing back. The back door had done the same. The windows Jake had worked on in what felt like another lifetime had absorbed the crowbar without comment. The walls bled water from every seam and showed no sign of running dry. The geometry of the building had doubled and tripled and rearranged itself they could barely recognize the layout anymore.

They had tried everything the building had presented them with.

The building had not run out of answers.

They stood in the roar of it — six people in chest-high water in a foyer that was still shrinking — the stillness between them fragile and uneasy.

Silence pulsed under the roar of the water.

"...Did you try the side entrance yet?"

The words came out thin and ragged, half swallowed by the noise, Danny pushing himself upright from Orel's shoulder with a wince as his ribs filed a formal complaint.

Heads turned. Leon's eyes narrowed, his breath harsh as he gave a single tired laugh, incredulous. "The Entity always puts a wall there. Hardly ever a door. And on the off chance it IS..." He gestured at the swollen back door, water lapping at his ribs. "It'll just be more of *this*."

The water lapped at Danny as he settled his back against the wall, and he spat once to the side, shoved his wet hair back from his face.

His expression settled into something that wasn't quite a smile — too waterlogged for that, too recently acquainted with the bottom of a hallway — but still showed the smallest spark of his usual dramatic flair.

"...You *do* know those walls are breakable, right?"

Ch 9 – Threshold

The school had stopped pretending to have a floor.

Not entirely — the taller ones could still find it if they stretched, toes scraping tile in the brief spaces between surges, just enough contact to push off from before the next wave took it away again. For the rest, it was just swimming, burning through limited reserves as they tried not to think about how close the ceiling was getting.

Nobody said it out loud. There was a direction now, which was better than the alternative. Better than standing in the foyer, waiting for the moment the building made the decision for them. They had a direction and they moved in it and that was enough to keep the other thought at arm's length.

The building had other opinions about all of this, naturally.

The flashlight barely reached.

Orela kept it forward and kept moving, but the beam gave them maybe three feet of visibility before the chaos swallowed it — water and noise and darkness pressing in from every direction. The school doing what it had been doing all night but with far less patience. The pipes were still screaming somewhere above them, muffled by the water but present, a constant high-pressure shriek that had stopped being startling a while ago and had become just another feature of the environment. Lockers banged open and shut along the walls in a violent rhythm. Ceiling tiles dropped without warning, each one landing with a slap of displaced water that soaked whoever was nearest, the spray cold and sharp against faces.

It was a gauntlet, not a hallway. A hydraulic cage fight, and the school was winning.

Conversation was functionally over. If you weren't close enough to shout directly into someone's ear, the water took your words before they arrived.

Dwight kept his focus on his own breathing.

In. Out. Arms moving. Head up. That was the whole job right now — not the ceiling, not the dark, not whatever was brushing past his legs in the churn. Just the breathing and the moving and the narrow column of air between his face and the surface. Anything to smother the panic skittering just under his skin. He wasn't a good swimmer. Never had been. The graceless thrashing of it was eating his energy and burning out his muscles faster than he could recover. But he couldn't stop. Couldn't sink. He had to keep his mouth *above* the water.

Something hit him broadside.

A chunk of debris — metal, fast, heavy, the edge of a locker door catching him across the shoulder and spinning him sideways before he'd registered it coming. He went under. The dark closed over his head and the noise inverted, muffled and enormous simultaneously, and for one disorienting second there was no up.

A hand caught him, painfully tight around his arm. He was yanked upward again, sputtering, hacking, blinking hard against the burn — only to find Danny clinging to him, wide-eyed and breathless, holding him up against the current. One hand was still locked around his arm, the other braced against the wall, his expression doing something complicated that resolved itself quickly into nothing at all.

"Don't drown on me, pencil neck," Danny hissed, tight against his ear as he pulled him back to the wall edge. "I don't want your death pinned on *me* unless it's actually my doing."

It was clearly meant to sound threatening, but it ended up being somewhat of a comfort to Dwight. Even the killer couldn't just let someone go out like that, it seemed.

Orela twisted in the water again, light flashing over both of them.

She was checking. Constantly. Refusing to let any of them vanish into the dark behind her. Her face was tight with effort. Eyes flicking between each survivor in turn — counting, clocking, making sure nobody had vanished into the dark between one glance and the next. The building had already demonstrated its opinion on unattended survivors and she wasn't giving it another opportunity.

Danny was moving better than she'd expected, the water doing the work his legs couldn't fully manage on their own, the buoyancy buying him a temporary reprieve from the pressure of gravity against his own injuries. She noted the wheeze in his breathing, barely heard over the water, and filed it alongside the wet coughs that had started cropping up in the others. There was nothing she could really do about any of it from here, anyways.

Leon had taken up a position at the edge of the group, shoulder-first into the current, methodically redirecting the debris that kept drifting in from the side passages. A cabinet corner. A floating shelf unit. Something that had been a door once and was now just waterlogged wood with ambitions. He caught them before they could find someone's head and shoved them aside without comment, jaw set, eyes forward.

The building pushed back.

The currents shifted without warning, tugging at legs from new angles, trying to bleed momentum out of the group and separate them one redirected stroke at a time. Ceiling tiles dropped in irregular intervals — not enough to be predictable, not random enough to be accidental — each one landing close enough to make a point. Debris drifted in from the hallway mouths like it had somewhere to be, and that somewhere was always directly in their path.

Every breath came in thick with rust and mold, the taste of it coating the back of the throat, heavy and biological and wrong.

Water surged backward down the hall, nearly dragging Orela into a wall. The next moment it shifted again, dragging Jake sideways into a doorframe. Lockers drifted like battering rams. Ceiling panels dropped seemingly at random. A pipe blew just above Leon's head, vapor hissing out before water collapsed down like a fist. He ducked, snarling, shaking it off.

The school wasn't trying to just drown them anymore.

It was trying to tire them out first.

The alcove appeared near the end of the hallway, as Danny had predicted.

Orela's beam caught the edge of it mid-stroke — a break in the wall, barely three feet across, tucked into the corridor like the building had forgotten to fill it in. One side was boarded up, the planks swollen and dark, water seeping through the gaps in thin steady threads that ran the wrong direction. Not draining out. Coming in, as if the entire building had gone under and the pressure outside was simply looking for the path of least resistance. Every surge that rolled

down the hallway made the planks flex, a subtle outward bow that suggested they had opinions about the situation and were getting louder about them.

The roar was marginally less here, enough that they didn't need to scream to be heard.

Orela pushed Danny and Dwight back into the nearby wall, using her body to brace them. She swept the flashlight across the warped planks, reading them, then felt Leon's hand close around hers and take the light.

He moved to the boards, running his palm across the grain, pressing at the edges, testing the flex. His jaw worked once as he bit down the urge to try and slam into it himself. Everyone had tried unsuccessfully to break one of these at some point in their time in the Fog, almost always hurting themselves in the process. The killers always made it look so easy.

Leon swept the flashlight across the planks one more time, jaw set, and stepped back.

He looked at Danny, gesturing to the blockage.

"Think you can break it?"

Danny looked at the planks. Looked at his own hands, still faintly trembling from the hallway. The robes were gone. The mask was gone. The terror radius, the cloak, all of it — gone. He'd been running on borrowed time since the moment the school flinched, and he knew what that meant better than any of them. The Entity's gifts came as a package. You didn't get to keep the strength while She took back everything else.

Or at least, he was fairly sure you didn't. He had no way to know for certain because killers didn't lose their gifts. Killers didn't end up treading water in a flooding preschool wondering if they still worked.

"I'm really not sure anymore."

Leon helped pull him into the alcove, bracing against the current as best he could so Danny didn't get torn away on him.

"Well, you're the only one of us with the clearance card. And it's not like we have other options here."

The alcove gave them maybe two feet of working space behind Danny, which wasn't much, but it was something.

He braced his back against the opposite wall, assessed the planks, and tried not to think too hard about the specific question sitting in the middle of his chest. Technically they weren't wrong. He'd broken killer walls before. Hundreds of times, probably — the muscle memory of it was there, the particular angle and force and follow-through. That part wasn't the problem.

The problem was that everything else had already been taken back.

If he didn't have the Entity's strength, he doubted his normal human strength would be enough to crack it, let alone break it. She hadn't shown any signs that She intended to spare him, so why would She give him such an easy out?

But what choice did he have?

He couldn't just wallow in his sudden abandonment when he was just as screwed as the survivors. He needed to be useful, which was a different thing entirely and required not having someone treating him like he was about to fall over. He could fall over later. Right now, he squared his hips to the wall, pulled his knee up, and drove his heel into the planks.

The kick landed solid through the water drag, the impact rattling back up through his hip and spine, water spraying across him in a sharp burst that made him flinch. His shoulders cracked against the wall behind him, jostling his ribs and reminding him of just how many were likely cracked.

The planks made an awful sound under the impact, but he could feel it through his leg. It hadn't shifted.

Danny gritted his teeth. He hadn't *felt* abandoned before. Not really. Not until now. If he couldn't get this wall open, what then? He could barely manage to stand in this current unaided. What if they realized he wasn't worth the extra hands to keep afloat?

Leon shifted his grip on Danny's arm and he jerked it away, moving to try again.

He didn't have the breath to explain it and didn't particularly want to — the reasoning was simple enough, if not flattering. He'd already been hauled out of a hallway once tonight. He'd already been stripped of his gear while he stood there and let it happen. He was not going to

stand in an alcove and be held upright like something that needed managing while he tried to do the one useful thing left available to him.

This couldn't afford to fail. They were going to leave him to Her fury; he just knew it. He slammed his heel against the wood, harder. The impact sent a dull crack of pain across his hip and up through his spine, water spraying into his face from the force of it. His shoulders took the wall behind him. The planks bent — actually bent, a visible bow outward, the wood flexing against the pressure — and the sound they made was significantly worse than the first time.

They held.

Danny stared at the bend in the wood. The water lapped at him. The thought floated up unwanted like debris in his mind— they had no reason to keep protecting him if he wasn't of use here. With how often he had hunted them, they would let the current take him back into the dark, and he would deserve it.

Distracted by that thought, the third kick missed its mark — his foot sliding wildly off the slick surface and sending him under with a surprised squawk — and the current had him immediately, pulling him sideways through a forest of legs in the dark.

A hand caught his wrist, halting his momentum and jolting his shoulder hard enough to hurt, dragging him up and back into the air. He broke the surface sputtering, shaking water from his eyes, and found Dwight — one hand locked around his wrist, the other braced against the alcove wall, breathing hard. Shaking visibly. The ghost of something that wasn't quite a smile on his face, there and gone, the universal language of *now we're even*.

So, they didn't just let him go after all. Well. Alright then.

Leon straightened, shoving his hair back from his face, water streaming off his shoulders. He stared at the planks. Ran the logic again. The wall had flexed. It had made the sound. It should have worked — by any reasonable measure of force applied to material, it should have given at least a little more than it did.

“Why didn't it work? It *should* have worked. You guys break these all the time!”

Danny looked back at him, ribs aching, hip singing from the second impact.

"I think... I think She might have fired me. The strength, the cloak... I don't know how long ago. I don't know if I have any of it left."

David's expression went through several things in quick succession as he let out a low, venomous snort. That was *it*. That was the *final goddamn straw*.

"Well, that's just fucking *great*." He pulled Leon aside, fitting himself in the alcove. "Killer wall, no killer strength. Fantastic."

He glared at the boards like they were a personal insult; his shoulder still raw from the back door, lungs burning, chest rattling.

"We don't have *TIME* for this shit!"

He planted his back against the opposite wall, and tilted his chin up from the waterline until he had an inch of air. Looked at the planks. Looked at the ceiling. Took the deepest breath he could manage.

Then with a deliberate jump, he drove both legs into the wall with everything he had.

The impact hit with a deep, booming crack, felt more than heard, the shock of it traveling up through the floor and into the legs of everyone in the alcove. The planks shuddered — the whole frame shuddered — and the seeping water coming through the gaps turned abruptly to jets, thin hard streams spraying into the dark.

David dropped sharply into the dark, water closing over him for one ungraceful second before he found the floor and shoved himself back up, resetting position against the wall and squaring up for another go.

"Wait, seriously?" Danny pulled himself higher on Orela's shoulder, trying to keep his face up. "Do you have any idea how much force it takes to crack that thing??"

"You got a better idea?!"

He'd broken killer walls. Knew exactly what it took — the particular combination of mass and force and the Entity's gifts behind it, the whole apparatus working together. Without the gifts, the math didn't work. A normal person hitting a killer wall was just a person hitting a very solid wall, and the wall won, and that was the end of it.

David hit it again.

The sound that came back was wrong. Not the dead thud everything else had made that night — something that carried, that traveled through the water in a pressure wave Danny felt in his teeth. The planks screamed. The whole frame shuddered, the seeping water through the gaps surging to angry jets that sprayed into the dark in thin hard streams. David dropped with the recoil, no support behind him, and was back in position before the current could make a decision about it.

The alcove tried to evict him anyway. The surge came from behind, the current finding the narrow space and accelerating through it, and David's footing went sideways. Jake lunged in to catch him, one hand locked around his arm, his uninjured leg wedged against a locker in the corridor like a human doorstop. He was coughing between breaths, the wet rattle of it sitting deep in his lungs, but his grip didn't waver.

Leon angled the flashlight.

David's face in the beam looked wild. There was no strategy in it, no calculation. All the light could see in his eyes was rage and stubborn determination. He found the wall again with both feet.

The boards flexed.

Held.

But the sound they made on the way back — the long, low groan of wood pushed past what it had agreed to handle — for the first time it sounded like they might actually break.

Ch 10 – Suspension

The rest of the space between the waterline and the ceiling vanished smoothly.

Four feet of it, then three, then two — the ceiling arriving in steady increments as the water found the last of the space and claimed it. They tipped their heads back, chins up, buying seconds. The pipes screamed above them, muffled now, translated by the water into something felt rather than heard. The lockers, the debris, the building's ongoing commentary — all of it reduced to pressure and distant collision, arriving through the water as vibration rather than sound.

And then the surface closed.

The noise the school had been making all night compressed into silence. David's kicks traveled through it in short concussive thuds, rhythmic and close, nearly as present as their own heartbeats. Everything else was stillness and dark and the heavy press of water from every direction.

Leon let the flashlight go.

He dropped it deliberately, the beam slowly eaten into the black as the current washed it down the hallway. He needed the extra hand to help anchor himself against the wall. Being able to see didn't matter anymore.

Either the wall broke and they wouldn't need the light, or...

He shook the thought off before it finished and turned his focus to the wall at his back and the person beside him. That was the whole job now. Stay still. Stay against the wall. Don't let the current make a decision for either of them. He got his arm around Dwight and pressed them both flat, narrowing the target, willing the water to find something else to pull at.

Dwight's hand found his sleeve.

The grip was immediate and tight, trembling in small, hiccupped pulses that Leon felt more than registered — every second stretching out longer than it should. He couldn't reassure the

man beyond tightening his own grip, so he just let the hand stay and kept them both against the wall and counted David's kicks moving through the water like a second heartbeat.

Dwight held on.

He couldn't tell if his eyes were open. The dark was the same either way, complete and total, pressing in from every direction. He didn't fight it. Years of trials had put something in him that wasn't courage exactly but functioned like it in emergencies — a flat, stubborn refusal to spend energy on what couldn't be helped. He was scared. He was tired. He was not particularly strong. But he could be still. He could last, if he stayed calm, if he kept his grip and kept his lungs and didn't think about how much time was passing.

He *could* last.

Probably.

The movement hit them from the side without warning — a flurry of it, close, maybe two feet away in the dark, turbulent enough that the current shifted and tugged at his legs with new intent. His hand tightened on Leon's sleeve. He felt Leon go rigid beside him.

Neither of them reached out.

Moving meant opening up to the current. Moving meant losing the wall. Moving meant finding out what that was, and there were only so many things it could be, and none of the options were ones they could think about right now without their bodies making a decision they weren't ready for.

They focused instead on the contact points. The texture of sleeves under fingers. The wall against shoulders. David's kicks moving through the water like a pulse. That was everything. That was all there was.

They stayed, anchored, and tried not to think about what was happening two feet away from them in the dark.

Orela had wrapped her arms around Danny's chest the moment the ceiling closed in. Now, pressed with her back tight to the wall, face tucked low and leaving small bubbles in his hair, she was holding him there — keeping him still.

Danny's hands were clamped over her arms, tight enough to hurt, as if her arms were all that stood between him and the darkness. She could feel the small hitches moving through him at irregular intervals, his body working against the stillness she needed from both of them.

She'd registered the wheeze in his breathing before they went under. Had noted it and filed it and told herself it was manageable. Down here, she could feel it — the shallow quality of what he'd managed to grab before the water took the last of the air, the way each hitch cost him more than it should have. Between the injuries from earlier and the exhaustion he hadn't had nearly as much time as the others to recover from, he hadn't managed to get a proper breath before going under.

She held him tighter and kept still and counted David's kicks moving through the water and tried not to let her hands shake. Her own lungs flared hot in her chest, but she focused only on *him*. If she could keep him still and calm, they both could make it.

Danny knew exactly how much air he had left.

That was the problem. In the hallway there hadn't been time to count — just the current and the dark and the animal insistence on the next breath. Down here there was nothing but time and stillness, and he had already gone in shorter than he would have preferred.

He tried to be still. Tried to let Orela's grip be the thing doing the work, to stop spending what he had left on anything that wasn't strictly necessary. It almost worked. The need to move started low, barely there, and crept upward with patient incremental certainty until it wasn't a suggestion anymore. He shifted, a small involuntary thing, trying to suppress what was building in his chest, and felt Orela's arms tighten in response.

Her palm pressed flat against his sternum. Taking inventory.

He felt her go still in a different way — the careful conservation of before replaced by the specific stillness of someone who had suddenly understood something. His grip shifted on her arms without meaning to, fingers searching for leverage, and the thought that arrived alongside it was not a thought so much as a demand.

Up.

She felt it in his hands before he'd finished processing it.

He fought it.

That was the thing — he knew what was happening, could name it with the specific clarity that made it worse, and fought it anyway. The need had moved past suggestion and into instruction, his body delivering the message with increasing insistence regardless of what his brain had to say about it. He got his fingers under her arms and pulled, not hard, not yet, just testing the possibility of *up*.

Her grip tightened.

His chest was stuttering, stomach spasming beneath her elbow. Every instinct in him screamed to move, but she had him locked. One arm was iron across his sternum, the other pulling his abdomen as close as she could manage.

Another hitch moved through him, sharper than the last, and his better judgment lost the argument. His hands found her wrists and pried, feet kicking for purchase, the animal logic of *up, out, surface* overriding everything else with a completeness that left no room for logic or reason. The current caught them from the side, almost dragging him out of her grip. She felt the twitch of a choice — that split second of fight or surrender — and chose for him.

She didn't stop to think. Just reached up and clapped her palm over his mouth and nose, fingers trembling with pressure, as she wrenched his head back against her shoulder to keep him from twisting away. She felt him register it. Felt the half second where he understood what she was doing and why.

The next second, he exploded.

His whole body torqued against her grip, one hard convulsive effort, hands clawing at her wrist, legs kicking at nothing. She held on. she wouldn't lose him. *Not like this*. If he tore away now, they may never find him again. She *needed* to not lose him to the dark. She could deal with the fallout later.

He bucked again, weaker, the reserves going fast, the water indifferent to how much he had left or how much he needed. She pressed his head back and held him flat and felt his chest seize against her palm, willing him to stop spending what he didn't have.

Stop. Stop. Just stop. Please just pass out...

His chest seized against her once, then again. She tightened her grip and held him there, a last blockade against the water, until the last jerk rolled through him like an aftershock — and stopped. She adjusted her grip and went still with him. Let her heart keep hammering against the fragile shape of his back. No wasted motion.

Just a silent prayer that she hadn't just made the worst decision of the night.

David felt every kick in his teeth.

The concussive thud of each impact travelled up through the water and into his jaw, his chest, the base of his skull. Terror burned hotter than exhaustion now, driving his legs back into the planks over and over. The wall was talking back now in a way it hadn't been before, something in the structure of it shifting under the assault, the flex coming back different from the dead resistance of earlier.

Jake had him.

That was the other thing he could feel — the grip on his upper arm, firm and present, the anchor that kept the current from sweeping him out of the alcove every time the recoil took his footing. He didn't make any motion to acknowledge Jake there. Couldn't afford the shift in focus.

The grip shifted.

He felt it happen — the tight clamp of a hand around his arm loosening by degrees, reorganising, fingers finding the fabric of his sleeve instead. He didn't look. He hit the wall again and felt Jake adjust behind him with a small tremor and filed that away too, in the same place he'd filed the sparks at the edge of his vision that had been there for the last three kicks and weren't getting better.

He shook off the sparks.

He knew what they meant. He'd felt that particular warning before, in other contexts, and he filed it in the same place he'd filed Jake's shifting grip and the way his lungs had been sending strongly worded letters of protest.

He re-braced. Drove his heels into the wall.

The vibration that came back was different — not the solid protest of before but something finer. A *true* sound this time. Short, fragile, but cutting through everything with a single distant crack. He felt it in his feet. Felt the board flex inward and catch.

There.

His chest hitched once as he backed against the wall for another kick. David's heart stuttered. He hauled himself back into position, boot slipping slightly—

His anchor had vanished.

Jake's grip slid from his arm and dissolved into the black. David whipped his head around, shot a hand after him, and hit only water. He held the reach for one suspended beat — Jake — and then let his arm drop and put his back against the wall and found the angle again.

No time. No point. *Refocus.*

Either Jake had been swept. Or he— no. No. If the wall didn't come down, none of it mattered. None of them. The board had cracked. He'd heard it. He could feel the flex in it had changed, the resistance giving way to something that felt almost like progress, and there was nothing left in the world except that and the next kick and the one after that.

Either the wall was breaking—

Or they all were.

Ch 11 – Emergence

Outside, the school was quiet.

The playground lay still in the perpetual night air, long shadows cast by nearby streetlamps highlighted half-rusted jungle gyms and faded spring riders in a sick yellow glow, the gentle chug of partially finished generators echoing through the otherwise silent domain.

The only thing different than the usual calm was the water.

It seeped through the cracks in the boarded wall in thin dark trails, following gravity down the planks and pooling in the mud below. The boards were dark with it, saturated, the wood swollen past its original shape.

A low thump rolled through the wall from the inside. Heavy. Close.

The planks creaked — a short, shrill sound, tight with strain — before a single long crack bloomed across the wood. For a moment, the stillness settled back in across the streets.

The wall gave another small creak, the crack widened ever so slightly—

—and everything gave way all at once.

The boards detonated outward into the playground with a concussive force that scattered every crow on the fence in one explosive black cloud, as a building's worth of black water tore free from the entranceway and coursed through the grass like a flash flood, churning up gravel and dirt.

The school forcefully vomited itself into the playground.

Planks cartwheeled across the yard. Plaster chunks hit the asphalt like cannon fire. A locker sailed overhead and buried itself in the fence with a shriek of metal on metal. Ceiling tiles skipped across the flooded grass like thrown stone. Debris churned through the bushes at the yard's edge, shredding leaves and snapping branches, the whole playground receiving everything the building had accumulated over the course of the night in a chaotic surge of flotsam.

And among the wreckage, tumbling out in the tide of furniture and broken tile and the last of the flood —

Six bodies.

David ripped his head free of the water with a strangled gasp.

The sound tore out of him raw and violent, barely a breath, more a seizure of the lungs finally allowed to do what they'd been screaming to do for the last sixty seconds. He dragged himself up onto his hands and knees above the receding flood, chest seizing, hacking until bile scorched the back of his throat. His vision pulsed with sparks — the same ones he'd been shaking off for the last four kicks, back with interest now, blotting the edges of everything in slow warning flares. Debris caught against his arms, adding to the small cuts and bruises as he fought to stay somewhat upright and out of the flood.

His boots scrabbled uselessly against the flooded grass, the motion still live in his legs long after it had any purpose. His body hadn't gotten the message yet. The momentum still lived in him, still screamed *move, survive, break through* — the instruction running on without the emergency that had issued it, burning the last of whatever he'd found below exhaustion against ground that didn't need breaking.

The tide began to recede just as David's arms gave out, the school finally finding an end to the flood.

He went forward into the churned grass and stayed there, breath hitching and hacking, fingers clawing at the mud like it could tether him to something solid. His whole body trembled, the ache in his limbs blooming hot and bitter, deep and cellular, acid poured straight into his veins.

But he could hear them. Around him, near him, the sounds of other people equally wrecked and alive — retching, coughing, tumbling through the debris. He could hear them.

He pressed his forehead into the mud and let out a breath that had been waiting a very long time.

Thank god.

Leon hit the grass rolling, momentum flinging him across the flooded yard in a sodden tumble of limbs.

The instinct was faster than thought — knees finding ground, legs pushing, upright before he'd registered that he was out. His eyes were already sweeping the yard, already cataloguing shapes in the debris, already trying to find headcounts through full body coughs that slammed his brain against his skull. His system was filing protests from every direction and he was ignoring every single one of them on the grounds that there wasn't time.

The ground tilted sharply under him, his legs buckling against the dizziness.

He staggered as the flood tried removing his position, planting a foot wide to catch himself, jaw locked against the grey that was creeping in at the edges of his vision. Not yet. He just needed a second. Just needed to see that they were all—

Jake hit him like a sack of wet concrete.

Shot out of the flood sideways, completely boneless, no warning, no trajectory that gave Leon any time to brace, Jake's full weight colliding with his legs, making him turn to try and compensate, inevitably taking them both down. Leon went backwards, spine and shoulders catching a discarded locker with a crack that he felt in his back teeth, Jake slamming down alongside him in the receding water, half across his lap, neither of them moving for a moment.

The world spun. Kept spinning.

Leon's chest heaved, the flood pooling cold around his ankles as if it hadn't finished with him yet, his vision doing something deeply unhelpful at the edges. He tried to push himself upright. His arms had opinions about that. He tried again.

His body made the decision for him — just a quiet, final withdrawal of cooperation, the accumulated debt of the last several hours coming due all at once. He felt it happening and couldn't stop it, could only register the specific indignity of going under sitting still, propped against a locker in a puddle, before it took him the rest of the way down.

He slumped against the locker with a soft grunt, head tipping to one side as his systems flickered out.

The collision knocked something loose in Jake's chest, and he coughed, rough and sputtering, like his body only just remembered how to exist.

He hadn't known he needed it to. One moment he was in the dark of the alcove with David's arm in his grip, and the next Leon's legs were there and the impact drove through him like a starting pistol, his body lurching into function on pure reflex.

For a moment, nothing worked right.

His chest hitched, trying to summon another round of hacking, the thin thread of air scraping through his throat like broken glass. *Not enough*. He convulsed once and managed to roll off Leon, collapsing sideways into the muddy grass as his insides revolted.

Water. So much water. Too far in, too deep down.

The heaving was violent and complete, his whole body locking up as the flood that tried to claim him came pouring back out in fits and stutters. He stayed down, forehead nearly in the mud, and let it happen, because there was nothing else to do and his body wasn't accepting other suggestions right now anyway. His limbs trembled with every retch — the ache in his leg flared white-hot as it twisted beneath him, a spike of pain so sharp it nearly reset his vision — but there was no room in his mind to process it yet.

The world was loud and bright and spinning at the edges.

He was barely aware of the yard around him — the debris, the receding water, the shapes of other people in various states of ruin nearby. He vaguely remembered darkness, pain. Could feel the echo of something that had been gripped tight in his hand. Something sharp against him. Why was his leg *burning* so much?

All he could register was air — precious, stinging air — and the desperate pull of his lungs trying to rinse the wet out of his bloodstream one gasp at a time.

Breathe first.

Everything else later.

Dwight slammed into the base of a twisted fence post, scrabbled against it to pull himself sitting upright out of the range of the tsunami that had carried him.

The metal was cold and bent and the most solid thing he'd touched in hours and he was not letting go of it. He clung there, wide-eyed, coughing up dark water in wracking heaves while his body sorted itself out and his brain tried to catch up with the fact that there was sky above him. Actual sky. Not ceiling. Not water. Sky, and air, and the distant amber glow of streetlamps filtering through the trees at the yard's edge.

A rogue corkboard clipped his leg on its way past, the last of the flood pulling it out in the nearby street to settle in the grass of a ditch. His breath hitched sharp, throat burning, eyes wide and stinging as he gagged up another mouthful of dark water that *should not* have been in his lungs.

Relief hit jagged — messy and out of order — colliding with the taste of rust and panic still thick on his tongue. His chest convulsed again, wracked by coughs he couldn't stop, but he *wasn't under anymore*. He was here. He was out.

And it was blindingly bright.

Even at this hour, even through watering eyes, the outside world hit him like a physical thing after hours of the flashlight and the dark. He squinted hard against it and it didn't help and he didn't care, because bright meant outside and outside meant out.

Something had hit him in the face on the way through. He couldn't place exactly when — somewhere between the wall coming apart and the fence post, a desk or a cabinet corner catching him across the cheekbone and peeling his glasses off. He could feel the throb of it already, the hot pressure of a bruise developing under his eye. Everything past a few inches was just colors and light and smeared shapes, adding to the blooming headache that promised to make the nausea worse down the line.

All of it felt like the best thing that had ever happened to him.

He pressed his forehead against the fence post and breathed.

Orela hit the ground flat on her back in the mud, the impact knocking what little air she had left straight out of her lungs.

She registered this slowly, in pieces — the sky above her, the cold wet ground beneath her, the violent convulsions that wracked her torso, dragging up more of the foul water in thick, painful coughs that rattled through her ribs like an aftershock. She blinked against the outside air, trying to get the world to resolve into something with edges, and mostly failed.

Something had weight on her arm.

She turned her head between spasms, following the pull, and found her own fist. Still closed, fingers locked tight around a handful of dark fabric. Danny's sleeve. She'd been holding it since the hallway, through the alcove, through the wall coming apart, through the yard — she'd held on through all of it without registering that she was doing it, and her hand apparently hadn't gotten the message that they were out.

She looked past her fist to where the sleeve led.

He was on his side facing her, close, unresponsive. Still. Water ran off him in thin streams into the mud. Cuts wept sluggishly at his hairline, his jaw, the raw patches along his forearms. A bruise had started forming along his jawline, dark and spreading. In the open air and the amber glow of the streetlamps, without the water and the dark to obscure it, he looked like something that had been through a great deal more than one bad trial.

His chest was moving. Just barely — a stuttered, shallow rhythm, that couldn't be nearly enough. Bit still. Stuttering. Present.

She released a breath she hadn't known she was holding.

Orela rolled toward him.

It took more than it should have — her arms shaking under her weight, the mud uncooperative, her chest still heaving between coughs that had no interest in waiting their turn. She got up onto one elbow and reached for his wrist, probing for that extra reassurance that she didn't actually —

He jolted beneath her touch, limbs twitching sharp and uncoordinated.

The movement was sharp and total, his whole body jerking away from the contact, eyes snapping open — wide, glassy, the whites catching the amber of the streetlamps. He tried to inhale and it caught somewhere in the middle, the breath seizing partway in, his hands scrabbling at the mud as he tried and failed repeatedly to push himself up.

"Hey—" she rasped, voice shredded and soaked, palm flattening firm against his sternum, trying to push him back down, grounding him with what little steadiness she had left. *"You're ok. Breathe."*

His eyes tracked. Slowly. Found her face.

The breath came in on the second try — ragged, effortful, dragging through him with an audible wheeze that she was going to think about later in her nightmares.

His body trembled as it rebooted — spine arching slightly, hands twitching where they'd curled toward his chest. He rolled fully onto his back with a pained sound and stared up at the sky, lips parted, trying to remember what lungs were supposed to *do*. His limbs hurt terribly, his chest felt bruised from the inside.

She stayed propped on her elbow beside him, watching his chest move, and felt something in her unclench that had been wound tight since she found her teammates washed up in the hall outside of the basement.

He couldn't form words yet. Might not for a while. His face was slack with fatigue, still trapped somewhere between fight and shutdown.

But he was alive. The natural rules of the trial domains that kept the survivors running through hell were working out here. He would recover. They all would.

And Orela — coughs still tearing through her lungs, dirt caked to her face, every limb screaming — laughed.

She'd gotten him out.

Behind them, the school looked... small.

Not dramatically — it hadn't collapsed, hadn't crumbled, hadn't done anything as overt as announcing that it was finished. It had simply stopped. The Entity, spent and denied, had withdrawn Her influence, and without Her the building had exhaled back into itself — the swollen doorframes shrinking to ordinary gaps, the bloated wood settling, the geometry quietly returning to something that matched its original footprint. The rotten blockades were gone as if they'd never been there. The hallways that had doubled and tripled in the dark were just hallways again. The lights inside flickered gently, soft yellow through cracked panes.

If it weren't for the playground, you might not have known.

The yard told the story the building no longer would — mud churned deep by the flood, dark puddles catching the amber of the streetlamps, debris scattered across the asphalt. Planks and plaster. A locker half-buried in the fence. The ghost of a hopscotch grid somewhere under all of it, invisible now, possibly permanent.

And six people.

Sprawled and propped and collapsed in various arrangements across the mud — waterlogged, bleeding lightly from a collection of minor and not-so-minor insults, flinching from the streetlamp glow that had no business being this bright after hours of nothing. Broken. Shaking. Alive.

All of them.

Ch 12 – Remnant

Someone found a medkit in a locked chest near the fence line.

Nobody questioned it — the Fog providing in the particular way it sometimes did, not generously exactly, but adequately. Orela took charge of it, grateful for something she could actually do something about, and went through the group in order of need.

Jake's leg first — the cut from the Entity's claw cleaned and wrapped properly, the makeshift bandana job finally retired. Dwight's collection of minor insults next, the desk-shaped bruise under his eye, the scrapes from the fence post, the general catalogue of having been bounced off several things at speed. Orela even found his glasses in a bush a short way from the fence, one lens cracked but both still in the frame, and watched something visibly settle in him when she put them back in his hands.

David and Jake were still coughing. The wet, rattling kind that didn't shift, that sat deep and announced its intentions to stay for a while. The others hovered, which David tolerated with approximately the same grace he tolerated everything tonight — jaw set, waving hands away, accepting help only when it was faster than arguing about it. Somehow, he was still upright, though even he wasn't sure how. Getting back to camp would likely see him sleep for days.

Leon came back around slowly, blinking against the streetlamp glow and fighting back random waves of nausea when the world refused to settle. A few tries to get upright. A brief, undignified introduction to what dizziness felt like when it really committed. He sat with his back against the fence and let the world sort itself out, head against his knees and shaking hands hidden away against his torso.

David slipped away from the group while Orela was occupied with Leon.

He didn't go far — just far enough to breathe without someone checking on him, rolling his shoulder and cataloguing the damage. The wet rattle of his lungs had settled in for the long haul, and every time he thought it was clearing it came back with interest. He'd deal with it. Nothing lasts in the Fog anyways.

Off to the farthest end of the yard, he could see Danny trying very purposely to keep to himself.

The man had found a section of fence to lean against, away from the group, and was attempting to wrap his own ribs with a strip of some random strip of fabric he sourced for who knows where. The attempt was not going well. His hands were clumsy with it, the fabric not cooperating, and every time he tried to pull it tight, he flinched and lost his grip and had to start over. It was obvious that he either had never done it before, or more likely had been in the Fog for so long that he had forgotten how to tend injuries. Being untouchable for years on end would have that effect, David mused, watching him struggle with the task.

It'd be funny if it wasn't so pathetic.

Something soft bounced off the side of Danny's head, making him startle slightly. He mentally cursed himself for the reaction, nerves entirely wound too tight. Unlike this damned fabric. Stupid shit kept coming loose when he tried to tie it.

Glancing down to see what hit him, his hands paused their work. Laying in the grass was a small roll of bandages.

He knew what those rolls did — had seen them work from the other side of a trial more times than he could count, watched survivors patch hook wounds and blade cuts in the middle of a chase and come back functional in minutes. The Fog's particular generosity with medical supplies had always struck him as one of its stranger qualities, that it would hand out tools that undermined the whole point of his job. But the point of the trial as a whole was fear, not damage, and fear didn't require permanent injury.

He'd just never had occasion to use one himself.

He picked it up. Looked across the yard.

David met his eye for a hard moment before turning to go back to the others, busying himself with getting everyone stable and upright, swatting Orela away for the 20th time in as many minutes.

Danny looked at the bandage roll in his hand for a moment longer.

Something complicated and uncomfortable settled into his chest, formless and unresolved, sitting alongside everything else the night had deposited there that he hadn't sorted through yet. He didn't have a name for it. Didn't particularly want to find one right now.

He unwrapped the bandage and got to work. The difference was immediate — proper materials doing the job properly, the ache in his ribs dropping from a shout to a manageable complaint. He'd be sore for a while. But leagues better than before.

The medkit died out too soon, as it always tended to do, but it was enough to get people functional. Walking-wounded functional, coughing-through-it functional, the usual grade of operational that the Fog seemed designed to maintain regardless of what the trial threw at

people. It was always a little insane how well those kits worked. Tonight it felt more insane than usual.

Nobody said it out loud — nobody had to. The trial didn't care what they'd been through. The gate wasn't opening without the work done, the campfire wasn't reachable without the gate, and standing in a flooded playground indefinitely wasn't an option anyone was willing to consider. So they went, in ones and twos, moving slower than usual but moving nonetheless, and finished what the night had interrupted.

The last generator caught with a familiar surge, and the group moved together in an exhausted slog toward the gate as it ground open with the same shriek of rust and neglect it always made. The Fog met them at the threshold, and the first tendrils of it were an absolute blessing. The ache in bruised bones softening at the edges. The rawness in waterlogged lungs dulling toward something that might eventually become ordinary tired. The sharpest edges of the last several hours filing themselves down into something the mind could carry without bleeding.

Danny trailed behind the group as they supported each other out of Bedham and towards the promise of a proper rest. Nobody had made a call for or against it. The logic had resolved itself somewhere in the yard while they were finishing the generators — he'd been there, he had nowhere else to be, and the group had collectively filed that under a problem for later and kept moving. He trailed a few feet behind David, water still dripping from his hair onto the gateway floor, and tried not to think too hard about what came next.

The Entity's barricades slammed up through the gate floor like knives, black and jagged, cleaving the path clean in half between Danny and the others. They howled as they emerged, shrieking metal and bone, driving a wedge between survivors and their tag-along. Everyone halted and turned back, the Fog briefly catching the shape of their surprise, as if the building and the water and the whole terrible night had temporarily made them forget what he was.

Danny didn't seem surprised.

The gate had never been his. That was just the shape of things. It had always been a survivor's exit — a path out of the trial and back to the fire. The best a killer could hope for, if they crossed it at all, was a return to their personal domain.

And Danny didn't have one.

He'd come into the Fog without a home — that was just the fact of it. No domain waiting for him, no personal architecture to return to between trials. He'd made do. He drifted. Crashed with others. Slept in corners of Myers' neighborhood when no one noticed. Used houses that had long since lost their original owners. It was a comfortable life, floating untethered from domain to domain, as if the entirety of the Entity's realm itself had been his home.

He'd never been to their campfire. None of his kind had. That door had never been open to him and he hadn't expected it to be.

Danny met David's gaze through the barricade, gave a tight nod he hoped was reassuring, and motioned for him to go on without him.

He stood on his side of the barricade and looked at Danny through the gaps in the spikes with that same unreadable expression from across the yard. For a moment he looked almost like he might come back to the barrier, eyes glancing over the spikes as if there was something to be done about them, before the tension dropped from his shoulders and he sighed lightly.

He gave a single nod. Small. The particular weight of it landing somewhere between acknowledgement and something Danny didn't have a clean name for. Then he turned and rejoined the group, and the Fog took them, and the gateway sat empty with its spikes still up.

Danny stood at the barrier for a while.

The Fog beyond it showed him nothing — just the soft grey of a domain's edge, the suggestion of a path he wasn't going to take. He watched the space where the group had been until his sides started to ache lightly again, the headache he had jolted back to awareness with threatening to return around the edges of his vision.

Nothing more he could do here anyways.

So, he turned back into the domain.

The street was quiet in the perpetual night of the domain — the generators finished, the gate opened, the survivors gone and the trial technically over. Whatever the Fog did with itself in the spaces between, it did it silently. Usually, he would have been spirited away by now and dumped into the next area. Being able to freely wander an empty domain after a trial felt wrong somehow.

Danny wandered the empty street, each step squelching softly through mud and silt, until the familiar bulk of the preschool rose into view again.

The surrounding area had taken the full force of the exit — the yard churned, the fence buckled in places where lockers had introduced themselves to it, plaster and debris scattered across the asphalt and pooling in the gutters. The building itself looked scoured. Pressure washed empty, and left to drip dry across the lawn.

It wasn't permanent. He knew that. The next time a trial was called here the Fog would reset the whole domain — pull the debris back, drain the water, restore the geometry to its original footprint and set the crows back on their perches as if none of it had happened. That was just how it worked. The Fog didn't hold onto damage.

He wasn't sure yet if that was a comfort.

The *absence* was what hit hardest. The rot, the weight, the invisible pulse of malice that had choked the walls for hours — it was gone. No pressure at the edges of his awareness. No sense of being observed. Just the domain, and the debris, and the distant sound of water still draining somewhere in the building's bones.

She had spent Herself on this. Used everything She had and come away empty-handed, and now She was simply — gone. Recovering somewhere in the architecture of Her own realm, presumably. Licking Her wounds.

He limped through the yard, sidestepping a half-sunk filing cabinet in the mud. His ribs reminded him of their existence with every step — the bandage was doing its work, but it's not like it could perform miracles. The debris was everywhere — lockers wedged against the fence at improbable angles, plaster smeared in wide arcs across the rusted swing set, a filing cabinet embedded nose-first in a flower bed that had never had flowers in it. The playground wore the evidence of the night — it, too, seemed to be a victim of the Entity's little game. He picked his way through it slowly, not in any particular hurry, the silence of it settling around him one step at a time.

He reached the side entrance and kicked a chunk of door frame out of the path. Then another. The broken killer wall gaped open above the debris line, the edges of it ragged and splintered outward, wood shrapnel scattered across the grass in an impressive radius.

Danny toed aside a chunk of molding, eyeing the wreckage with something almost like respect.

The damage was impressive. Not just the final breach — the whole face of the wall told the story of what had happened in the alcove, the wood bearing the accumulated record of every kick in a pattern of stress fractures that radiated outward from the centre. Whatever the killer walls were made of, it wasn't meant to come apart like this. It wasn't meant to come apart at all. That was the point of them.

Danny ran his fingers along the splintered edge, reading the force of it in the grain.

"...Gold star, brawler," he muttered with a slight chuckle.

The stocky little brat had been underwater, out of air, running on something past exhaustion and past rage and past whatever came after rage — and he'd broken the damned wall anyway.

Danny pulled his hand back from the wood.

He turned the thought over once, quiet and private in the empty domain. If the man ever had the inclination to swap sides — the desire, the circumstance, whatever it would take — he would be a genuinely terrifying thing to face in a trial. The Fog would probably be delighted. The survivors considerably less so.

Danny leaned against the doorframe and let it hold some of his weight.

The ribs made themselves known about that, a low persistent complaint that the bandage was managing but not solving. He'd be dealing with them for a while. He was used to discomfort, generally speaking — the Fog had a particular relationship with pain that kept things functional without making them comfortable — but this was a specific, personal kind of ache that felt different from the usual wear of a trial. More earned, maybe. Definitely deserved, at the very least.

He leaned against the splintered doorway, letting his shoulder slump against the frame. The hallway inside was back to normal. Tight. Short. Still cracked and peeling in that aesthetic decay way, but no longer a shapeshifting maze full of pressure and current. No longer a black chasm of currents and chaos. No screaming.

He hadn't expected to feel anything in particular about that. Still, there was a strange sort of relief; the specific comfort of a space that was just a space again and wasn't trying to kill anyone. After the hallways stretching and the currents and the pipes and the ceiling arriving in increments, ordinary was something he could handle. Ordinary gave him the time to stop, rest a bit, and let the silence of it settle around him, trying not to think too hard about what came next.

He pushed off from the doorframe.

There was likely somewhere in the building that was probably drier than the rest of it. If not, there were other small, busted buildings in the area that would suffice. He could sleep off the ribs and the shaking and the general accumulated damage of the night, and then figure out the rest from there. That was enough of a plan for now.

Turning to start up the hunt for a passable nap spot, something caught his eye.

He stopped. Turned back slowly, not sure yet what he'd seen, just the peripheral awareness of something that didn't fit — a quality of light, a stillness that struck differently somehow. One of the classrooms off the main hallway. He looked at it for a moment from the corridor.

A single desk sat in the middle of the floor.

The rest of the room was the same wreckage as everywhere else — waterlogged, debris-strewn, the detritus of the night settling wherever gravity had put it. But the desk was clear. Centred. The streetlight came through the window at an angle that caught it directly, the amber glow pooling across the surface, making it look almost like an altar.

He drifted forward, feet whispering through the remaining puddles that sat still and undisturbed on the tile.

In the center of the desk sat his robe. Clean. Dry. The leather smooth and unmarked, the canvas underlayer pressed flat, the whole thing arranged with intent that bordered on domestic care. His mask rested on top, face up, the white of it catching the streetlight from the window. His phone and knife bordering it to either side.

All of it exactly as it had been before the night started. His entire identity, returned to him like a present. A prize for surviving. Maybe a punishment for not dying.

Danny stood in front of the desk and dripped quietly onto the floor.

He looked at his things for a long moment without touching them, the clear message from them gently circling his mind.

Time's up. Get back to work.

That was what this was. Not a gift — it had never been a gift; he understood that now with a clarity that the night had earned him the hard way. A summons. The gear cleaned and folded and waiting, because tools got maintained between uses, because that was what you did with something you intended to keep using. The cleaning wasn't kindness. It was just upkeep.

He'd known, in the abstract, that this was how it worked. He'd always known. The killers weren't here because She loved them — they were here because She needed them, and need was a transactional thing. He'd told himself the autonomy he'd carved out was real, that the space between the trials was his, that the arrangement was something he'd chosen to participate in rather than something he'd been slotted into.

The water in the schoolyard said otherwise.

She had turned Her domain into a trap and put him in it with the survivors without warning or protection, and when it stopped serving Her purposes, She had simply — withdrawn. Left him to whatever came next. The gear on the desk was not an apology. It was a reminder of what he was for, laid out under a streetlight like a receipt.

He knew better than to disobey. He had seen what Her displeasure looked like up close tonight, felt it in the current that had no interest in which side of the trial he was supposed to be on. If She decided he wasn't worth the trouble of maintaining, that was simply what would happen.

They were all tools. Every one of them. Expected to be grateful She'd found a use for them at all.

He picked up the robe.

The leather was dry. Clean. Lighter than it had been in the hallway, obviously — waterlogged was a different animal entirely — but he suspected She had given back his strength before withdrawing as well. He stood with it in his hands for a moment, feeling the familiar weight of it.

Eventually, with hands that trembled more than he wanted to admit, he dressed.

Layer by layer, the same way it came off — in reverse, without ceremony, the buckles finding their positions with the muscle memory of a hundred trials. The cowl. The gloves. The whole assembled architecture of the thing, rebuilt around him in the amber light of an empty classroom while water dripped quietly in the hallway behind him.

He picked up the knife last.

Ran his thumb along the worn edge of the handle, the familiar curves of it sitting in his palm exactly as they always had. He waited for the thing that usually came with it — the sharpening of attention, the quiet pleasure of holding something he was good at using. The sense of himself clicking back into place.

It didn't come.

He closed his hand around the handle anyway and slid it home.

He knew how the next trial would go. He'd stalk, and he'd slash, and he'd play the game the way he'd always played it, because that's what was expected of him and he knew better than to refuse. He'd find the rhythm of it again eventually. Maybe even the fun. The Fog had a way of smoothing things over, filing the edges down, making the distances between things feel longer than they were.

But for a select few, he would hold back.

Not many. Just a handful. Just enough to make a difference that nobody would be able to measure or name — a fraction of a second's hesitation, a hook instead of a blade, a hatch left open for no particular reason. Not mercy. He wasn't prepared to call it that.

Just a fraction.

Just enough.

The smallest seeds of doubt, buried deep in the Fog.